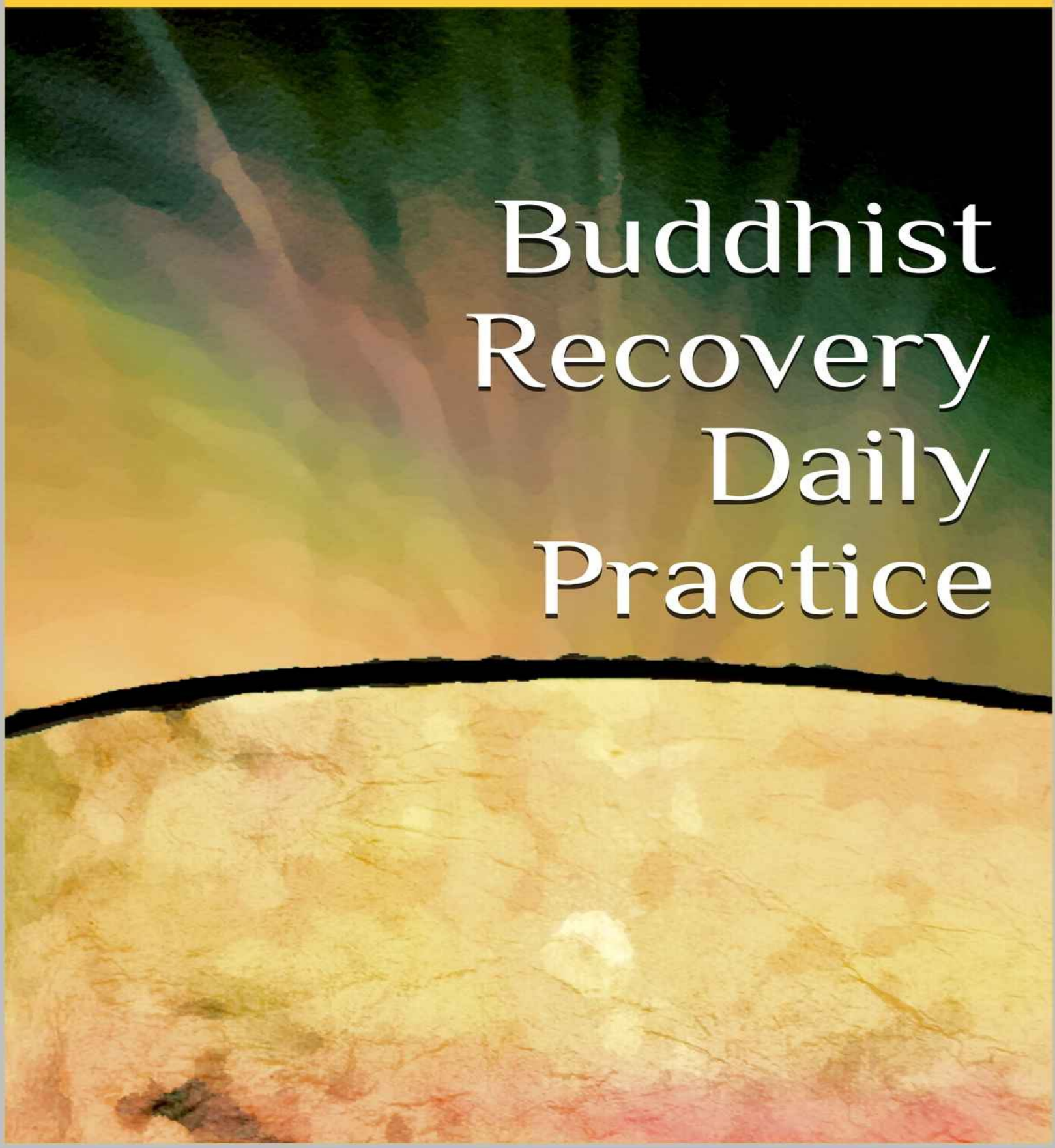
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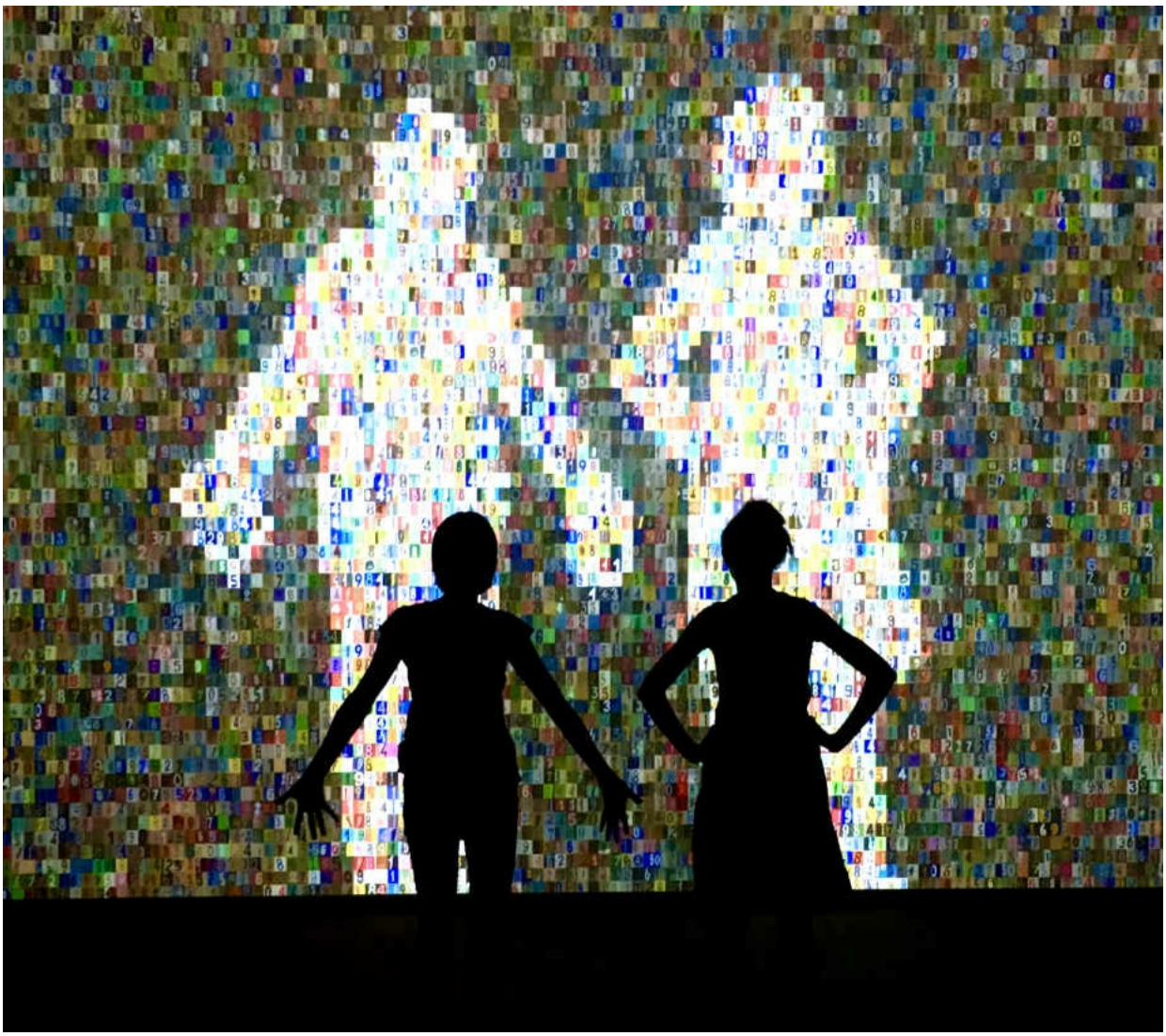
Buddhist Recovery Daily Practice



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Sheldon Clark

ADDA Press and Media



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Each morning we are born again.
What we do today is what matters most.

Jack Kornfield

With gratitude to the teachers
who have guided me well.

Teshin Matthew Sweger
Josho Pat Phelan
Ryushin Paul Haller
Shōhaku Okumura
Tenshin Reb Anderson
Zoketsu Norman Fischer
Bhikkhu Analayo
Shantideva
Thich Nhat Hanh

Contents

Title Page
Copyright
Epigraph
Dedication
Preface: Siddhartha’s Four Signs
Introduction
Practices in Thought
Practices in Word
Practices in Deed
Postscript
Thoughts on Meditation
Glossary
Notes
Suggested Reading
Appendix

Preface: Siddhartha's Four Signs

Sidd:hartha Gautama was born 2600 years ago in northern India to the royal family of the Shakya clan. On the day of his birth, a seer came down from the hills. When the king asked the seer about his son's future, the seer said that the child would either be a great political leader, or a great spiritual teacher.

Siddhartha's father needed an heir and was determined that his son should grow up to take his place. He kept Siddhartha in the palace from that day forward, making sure that his every need and want were met. Siddhartha led a life of opulence and leisure, with friends, women, sumptuous meals, music, and games fulfilling all of his sensual desires. Surely, the king thought, this would keep his son at home and on the path to power.

And for a time it did. The boy Siddhartha became a man, married a woman named Yoshodhara and had a son, Rahula. As Siddhartha entered adulthood, however, he realized that he had never seen the world beyond the palace walls. He told his father that he wished to visit the nearby city and his father planned a great parade, an event he was sure would keep his son protected in a cocoon of wealth.

But as the parade proceeded, Siddhartha looked down a side alley and saw an old man, bent with age. With his attendant, Channa, Siddhartha followed the old man, questioning Channa all the while about what it meant to be old, how it was that someone could become infirm. As they left the parade and went further into the city, Siddhartha came across more old people, many of whom were clearly sick and suffering from disease. At last he saw death, a corpse lying near the river about to be cremated.

All of this stood in stark contrast to the life Siddhartha had lived until then. He wondered that such suffering existed and knew then that he, his wife and his child, his father and mother, would all grow old, become sick, and die. Old age, sickness and death. These three signs affected Siddhartha deeply, bringing both revulsion and a desperate clinging that he soon found to be sufferings all their own. How, he wondered, could people live happy and fulfilling lives in the face of such hardship?

Then, as Siddhartha and Channa made their way back to the parade, Siddhartha saw someone else, a monk meditating in the shadow of a doorway. This was Siddhartha's fourth sign that day, that through spiritual practice there might be a way to escape the suffering of life. He vowed then to find the answer for himself, and to share it with others. He left home, spent years exploring different spiritual paths, and finally achieved awakening. From then on, he was known as the Buddha, the awakened one.

This book is not so much about the first three of Siddhartha's signs. We know that there is suffering in life. If you've struggled in addiction, or are struggling now, you likely know it quite keenly. Rather, this book is about the fourth sign, the promise of a path forward.

Introduction

I have always been amazed and grateful for how well the Buddha's teachings apply to recovery. The first two of the Four Noble Truths speak clearly to anyone in addiction: first, that there is suffering, or dis-ease, in life; and second, that our dis-ease springs from indulgence in the three poisons of greed, hatred and delusion—from our own clinging and aversion.

And what a gift the third and fourth Truths are for people who are suffering: the third truth, that suffering can end; and then the fourth, the Eightfold Path's inspirations for change. These ideas are developed in books such as *Recovery Dharma*, *Eight Step Recovery*, and *Refuge Recovery*.

Buddhist Recovery, Daily Practice is offered as a companion to these texts. The purpose of this book is to offer ideas and practice suggestions to those who feel called to continue their exploration of recovery along a Buddhist recovery path. The ideas covered here help us to develop a deeper understanding of our own nature, and of those around us. It's about considering ideas which help us show love and care, and to lessen our own suffering as well as the suffering of others.

I grew up in the Episcopal Church. As I got older, I found that I couldn't continue on that path, but there was a phrase which I had heard, Sunday by Sunday, that's stayed with me over the years—something to do with our "thoughts, words, and deeds."

So much of my life as a Buddhist, in and out of recovery, has centered around understanding how my mind works, seeing the tricks that I play on myself, and the holes of despair I've jumped into all too willingly. And, as this understanding has grown, to see how these tricks and holes affect the ways that I speak and the things that I do. Thought, word, and deed—key elements of the Eightfold Path: right thought, right speech, and right action.

While my primary Buddhist practice is in the Zen tradition, much of Buddhism's influence in my recovery work has fallen squarely in the teachings which came from Buddha's time and place, northern India, 2600 years ago. Practices such as the Eightfold Path, using breath in meditation to establish mindfulness, and observing precepts have been important tools in the work of my sobriety.

As a Zen practitioner, though, I also believe that Buddhist practice isn't simply about bettering oneself. Living in an understanding of our interdependence with all things, I've come to see life and recovery as an opportunity to practice with love and care for those around me. I believe it's important that we seek not only our own sobriety and awakening, but to live in such a way that we help others also awaken to a life of comfort, ease, and harmony. To honor that gift, to bring forward love and care in my day-to-day life, I know that I need to be ever mindful of how I cultivate my own life, and how I relate to others.

This book is divided into three sections. The first section, Practices in Thought, offers ideas on how to shape our thinking, from disciplining our minds into a more positive stance, to cultivating patience, and considering the generators of happiness in our lives.

The second section, Practices in Word, naturally deals with right speech. More particularly, however, this section also includes taking refuge in the Buddha, Dharma and Sangha; the merit in reciting a repentance verse, or gatha; and a consideration of what are known as the three "pure precepts."

The third section, Practices in Deed, considers the idea of bowing as part of daily practice, especially in conjunction with reciting the refuges. This is followed by a discussion of ethical conduct and the five precepts, and developing a practice of generosity. The section concludes with a discussion of the Bhramaviharas, or the Four Immeasurable Minds, which serve as a foundation for Right Action.

I have discussed many of these ideas in Buddhist settings, where the idea of awakening has a certain contextual meaning. As I've worked with these same ideas in Buddhist recovery settings, however, I've had to broaden my language to keep the work of sobriety in the mix.

Sobriety and awakening—are these two different things? By strict definition, the answer would need to be yes. But I also know from personal experience, and through friendships in my recovery sangha, that getting clean from substances and working toward clarity in sobriety often feel like an awakening. Awakening from a clouded, dark place. Awakening from choices and behaviors which benefit neither ourselves nor others. Awakening into new ways of being. Awakening into sobriety.

At the very least, there seems to be an affinity between the words sobriety and awakening, if not perhaps an exact alignment. And so after a lot of consideration, I have chosen to use the phrase "sobriety and awakening" in order to encompass both.

There are many Buddhist practices which can lead us toward an awakened way of being and, as I said earlier, we

have all seen how well these ideas can be used to develop and support sobriety. In using the term "sobriety and awakening," I am recognizing the value of Buddhist practices in both Buddhist *and* recovery settings. I'm celebrating the lifting of the veil that sobriety brings to our sense of dis-ease. But most importantly, I'm affirming my own belief in a fundamental link between the idea of awakening and the work of sobriety—my own view of a commonality in their purpose and result.

As you continue to read, you'll see that while I honor Buddhist practices which lead to individual awakening, I also believe that a natural result of these practices is to support others in their own path toward awakening. So too, while I honor anyone's path of recovery leading to sobriety, I believe that our work in sobriety is not only for ourselves. We must also support the well-being of others—those with whom we are in relationship, as well as others within the recovery community.

This book offers ideas and practices which apply to sobriety *and* awakening. May you find your way along both paths.

❀

Practices in Thought

Right now… right now… we have a chance to find and allow happiness into our lives, rather than discontentment and misery.

❀

Happiness is a blessing. We know intuitively that being content means that we feel better about ourselves, and when we feel better about ourselves we can relate more easily with others. Happiness makes it easier for us to bring love and compassion into our own lives and, when we do, to join with others in community. Community is a blessing, too.

Preparing the Mind

Poisons of the Mind

But there are attitudes we harbor which can keep us from feeling content, from being happy and sharing ourselves with others. One is when our mind is full of preconceptions and opinions. How many times have we gone into a situation, or to meet with another person, already filled with ideas about what things will be like before we even get there? Or, once we become involved in a situation, how often do we form opinions which we then set into stone, unwilling to allow what we think to change or to grow? When this happens, we close ourselves to possibilities, new discoveries, and to things which could be a welcome surprise.

A second attitude which can stand in the way of happiness is when our minds are so cynical and critical that everything becomes colored by the harshness of our judgements. Sometimes we're just on the lookout for what what we think is wrong, for what we don't like, or what we won't accept. Rather than hold ourselves open to what we might enjoy, we tell ourselves stories about why we can't accept something. Our happiness never even stands a chance.

A third attitude which hinders our ability to engage with happiness is when our minds are lost in distraction. It's easy to be distracted, especially with our phones bringing every piece of news right before our eyes. Not to mention Facebook, Instagram, the thought to share a selfie, or to check to see if we have missed a text.

How can we engage with the world in meaningful ways in the face of so many distractions? Thich Nhat Hanh once said that the present moment is the only place where happiness can be found. The past is gone, he said, and the future not yet here. It's only in the moment, moment by moment, that we can we engage with our hearts and find something to be happy about.

Right now… *right now.*.. we have a chance to find and allow happiness into our lives, rather than discontent and misery. Our best growth comes from inner strength and generosity, Nhat Hanh said, rather than fear and greed. That strength, and the living of a generous life, can only be found in the present moment. We should work to find these things now, he teaches, because it might not be so easy later on.

So, why do we engage in mind states which stand in the way of happiness? Why do preconceptions and opinions cloud our perception? Why are we so critical sometimes? Why is it so hard to not be distracted?

Different Buddhist traditions speak of the hindrances with which we all struggle, things like doubt, attachment, aversion, and fear. These strong emotions often lead us into suffering mind states like aggression, craving, jealousy, arrogance, and pride, especially when we are clouded by the effects of active addiction. These things lurk in our psyche, and they often work against us without our even knowing. Shantideva, an 8th century Indian Buddhist monk, saw this clearly:

No other enemy

Has lived so long as my defiled emotions.
O my enemy, my afflicted passions,
My endless and beginningless companion…[1]

Shantideva's language is strong here, and perhaps needs a little unpacking. Of course, our emotions are not our enemies; they are a natural part of life. In terms of Buddhist-oriented recovery work, our emotions actually serve a valuable purpose—helping us to feel where we're getting stuck, where there are things we need to address, and where we need to bring our attention. But the danger Shantideva speaks of, the enemy of our own well-being and that of others, is when powerful emotions are left to grow without our taking time to acknowledge and understand them.

Dissolving the Hindrances' Power

The best way I have found to work skillfully with the power of these hindrances is with wholehearted attention. With determined awareness and a measure of self-compassion, we can learn to short circuit the seductive power of the hindrances and poisons which plague us.

This is a process, however, and it takes time and practice. We have to develop an awareness of our bodies, our feelings, and our minds. How do our interactions with people and situations effect us, physically, emotionally, and mentally? Developing this kind of awareness is important for anyone who wants to understand their own responsive patterns in life. It's even more important for those of us in recovery, where much of our work is to see the reactive patterns which have become unskillful in our addiction and to transform them into new, skillful patterns of understanding and communication.

How do we build this awareness? A Buddhist recovery path teaches us the value of developing mindfulness through meditation. There are a variety of possibilities, ranging from simple breath awareness or practices of loving kindness and forgiveness, to more formalized practices as taught directly by the Buddha. Regardless of the practice used, however, the goal is to cultivate a sense of mindful awareness. In time, we can learn to bring this awareness forward as a tool to examine our motives and actions, and their repercussions on ourselves and others.

Practices:

- Find a quiet place where you can create a regular meditation space. Keep it simple, but you may want to have an altar with flowers, a candle, and perhaps an image of the Buddha. Take care in locating and creating this space. Spend time there and make it your own. Decide what your meditation posture will be. You might use a chair, a meditation bench, or a cushion. Find your comfortable meditation posture, take several deep breaths and allow your body to begin to settle. Just this much is an important practice.
- Each time you sit, take a few moments to scan the muscles in your face, your jaw, the root of your tongue to see if they are tense. Take deep breaths and see if you can help these muscles to relax. Expand your scan through your shoulders, arms and hands, and down through the remainder of your body. As your body begins to relax, you will come to find yourself feeling more rooted in your posture. Be sure to keep your back straight, but not rigid. Let your ears be above your shoulders, with your head level, your eyes closed or gently cast down. Let your hands rest comfortably in your lap. Take time to repeat this exercise until you can reliably take your meditation posture in a relaxed, upright, dignified way. This is the basis of all meditation practice.
- Practice breathing with awareness, bringing a sense of mindfulness to your breath. Get to know the nature of each breath, remembering that your breathing doesn't need to be any special way; it only needs to be your own. As your mindfulness of your breath deepens, suffuse it through your entire body. Let there be a union of breath and body in each moment, moment by moment. Continue with this practice until it feels natural.
- Begin to notice feelings and thoughts as they arise in meditation. Don't try to unpack their causes or to analyze them. That's important work, but there are other times to do it. As you sit in meditation, simply see these things as they arise and quietly name them: This is fear. This is boredom. This is anger. This is loneliness. This is excitement. The goal is not to change these thoughts or make them go away, but simply to see them and recognize what they are. In doing so, you may find that a bit of space opens up around your thoughts and feelings, and that you can begin to observe them rather than be swept away by them.

Disciplining the Mind

The Place of Self Discipline

In recovery, self-discipline isn't simply about not picking up a drink, or having another smoke. In order to really heal ourselves and our relationships, we must also be disciplined in how we think, which in turn governs our choices in how we speak and act. Shantideva encourages us to live by a code of behavior, one of our own making and applied in the ways we know to be best:

Those who wish to keep a rule of life
Must guard their minds in perfect self-possession.
Without this guard upon the mind,
No discipline can ever be maintained.

But what is this code, this rule of life? How can we know what it should be? How do we judge our success, and how do we know when we've fallen short?

The fruits of meditation can certainly help here. In time, honest self-examination through meditation begins to reveal our greed and cravings, our aversions and aggression, and the arrogance and pride which keep us apart from others. We see their effect on ourselves and on those around us. We feel the suffering they cause and, in our awareness, we begin to develop natural changes in our behaviors.

As this process unfolds, there are things we can keep in mind as ideals that will serve us well. Call them disciplines of the spirit. The word *discipline* sometimes gets a bad rap—invoking the idea of punishment, or of being pressured into doing something we'd rather not do. But when we think about the origins of the word, we can find a different perspective. In Latin, the word *disciplina* means "instruction given, or teaching." More importantly, the word also means simply "learning, or knowledge."

In this light, we can consider a "discipline" in life to be something by which we learn, by which we awaken ourselves to what matters most in relation to our values in sobriety.

The Three Disciplines

Not Causing Harm

We all cause harm at some point, to ourselves and to others. Sometimes this is intentional, sometimes not; either way, damage is done. We cause suffering, and we have to deal with the consequences.

Developing and applying mindfulness can help us into a mindset dedicated to non-harm, to caring for the well-being of ourselves and those in our community. But first we have to see the harm that we do and, more importantly, when and why we do it.

Our actions, harmful or otherwise, manifest out of a chain of events. We have perceptions in our experiences which then formulate into reactive feelings. These feelings create thoughts, and our thoughts lead to actions.

Sometimes we are unaware of our feelings and don't clearly see the roots of our thinking. Meditation and mindfulness can help with this. With mindful awareness, we can become more aware of different moments, different links along the chain. And with this awareness we can see more clearly our opportunities to make choices. Moments when, with attention, we can skillfully work to refrain from harming others.

The Tibetan Buddhist teacher Pema Chodren asks us to consider three moments of choice: before our thoughts take hold; when thoughts have ensnared us; and before our thoughts lead us into action. The first, before our thoughts take hold, is when our thoughts are small, when our perceptions have created feelings but we're just becoming aware of them, before we even really begin to put them into thoughts and words. What if, with mindfulness, we can learn to experience our perceptions, to see them without judgement, and not respond to them by either clinging to them or trying to push them away? How might that effect our thoughts as they develop?

When we observe and understand our feelings as they arise, we're less likely to get swept into reactive thoughts about how we're feeling. Instead, we can gain a little space in the moment, and make choices about how we will respond.

The second moment of choice is when thoughts have ensnared us. Sometimes our thoughts beat us to the punch. Our opinions and judgments roar into being and we become ensnared, no longer really in touch with what's happening—with what another person may really be saying, or what a situation may really be about.

When reactive feelings color our perceptions of what's happening we're less able to see things clearly, to see them as they're being presented to us. As a result, we're more likely to respond in ways that have more to do with our own fear, irritation, or agenda than with what is really going on.

What if instead we can learn to recognize when we're filtering things through our own judgements and interpretations? Can we learn to set these aside, or to at least be aware of their impact on our thinking? If so, we can reopen ourselves to the reality of what's going on right in front of us.

The third moment is before our thoughts lead us into action. This may be the most challenging moment of the three and, unfortunately, the moment where we often find ourselves. We experience perceptions in an interaction with someone. We begin to experience different feelings based on what we have perceived: we want to change where we are or to be with someone else; we wrestle with anger and aversion, the need to put something away from us; or we struggle with greed, attachment and longing.

How do we stop ourselves from unskillful behavior in moments like these? How do we get out of the way of a speeding train? Might it be as simple as just stepping aside? Logic would tell us yes. The power of our feelings and emotions, however, often say otherwise.

Practices:

- As your meditation practice has become more regular, you've hopefully become better able to see the reactive patterns of your thoughts and feelings. At first, feelings or thoughts will come into being and you may only realize it after some time. With practice, you will be able to recognize and name them even as they arise. Stay with this valuable practice.
- With time, you'll find that your ability to recognize and name your thoughts and feelings during meditation will begin to extend into different situations and interactions in daily life. Work to examine your perceptions and feelings in different settings. Does a particular situation make you feel anxious or angry? Are there certain people who put you on edge? Recognizing these things in the moment can help you to distance yourself from their ensnaring power. In this space, you can find room to examine what you're feeling and understand things better. You can begin to make choices in this space of understanding.
- As you come to know the feelings and thoughts you have in different situations, you can begin to prepare yourself for them ahead of time, and guide yourself into different, more skillful ways. With mindfulness, consider the ways you perceive what is happening in different settings. Are your perceptions accurate? In

what ways might you be misinterpreting what's happening? Are you taking into consideration the feelings and needs of other people? Practice using mindfulness to recognize perceptions, feelings and thoughts as they occur. Review situations and interactions after they happen and consider the feelings you had. Ask yourself how you might have responded differently.

Gathering and Dedicating Merit

Buddhist ideas of virtue and merit are often misunderstood. Buddhist ceremonies, and Buddhist recovery meetings for that matter, generally end with a dedication of merit. But what are we talking about when we speak of merit? The short of it is that merit is the fortunate result of our wise and skillful actions. In dedicating merit we offer the positive results of our good intentions and actions.

Merit is like an ethical force that we can direct. If we live our lives with right intention and right action we create a positive energy force; we create merit. If we put this merit out into the universe, consciously and with good intention, we can have faith that it will have good effect, even though we may not see the result.

Dedicating merit is where imagination meets reality in a positive way. With imagination we think to share merit with all beings, and in the reality of our days we work to do just that, moment by moment, with person after person.

Shantideva again:

Speak with honest words, coherently,
With candor, in a clear, harmonious voice.
Abandon partiality, rejection, and attraction,
And speak with moderation, gently.

It took time before I came to a full appreciation of how much of our path in Buddhism is an expression of simple goodness. We forget sometimes how Buddha's teaching can be transformative for our hearts. From steps on the Eightfold Path leading toward a more just life; to practices of patience, generosity, and ethical conduct; to the four immeasurable minds of loving kindness, compassion, shared joy and equanimity, there is much here which speaks of a life dedicated to the betterment of all.

Over time, steady contemplation of these ideas got through to me. They became part of me and shaped my practice and recovery. I really began to think about them before my first son was born. I wanted to be the best father that I could be, but I needed patience. I needed to understand right action. I learned to see his face as a mirror for my own expression of loving kindness and compassion. I offered my practice then to his well-being.

That doesn't make me special. Over time, dedicating the merit we find in our Buddhist recovery practice helps us see that our practice itself is goodness, in and of itself. We don't gain merit in practice, we generate it. It isn't ours. We can't keep it. It isn't for us. All we can do is offer it, and when we do, we begin to see its potential ripple outward to those around us.

It's this goodness, the goodness of our own hearts and minds engaged in practice, that we recognize and share. Dedicating merit expands us out beyond ourselves, beyond the idea that we're practicing because it's good for us.

Of course, it's not that practice isn't good for us, but we can't just stop there. When we dedicate merit, we're taking the wholesome purpose of our recovery and practice and expanding it outward into the universe at large.

It's an act of radical imagination: that all beings can be free, that everyone can be at peace, that everyone can recover and awaken—and that we have a part to play in this.

Practices:

- As you learn to work more skillfully with your thoughts and feelings, consider how this generates a sense of well-being for yourself and for others. Observe how your skillful understanding of feelings and thoughts leads you into more skillful interactions.
- As you end each meditation period, say or chant a dedication of merit. This will help you to deepen your commitment to your recovery practice. Try this: "I dedicate the merit of my practice to everyone. May those in fear find peace through understanding, and see uncertainty as part of life. May everyone awaken to compassion and ease. May we share freely all that we have been given, and may our practice be an offering to the well-being of all beings everywhere."

Benefiting Others

All of these ideas and practices culminate in the conscious decision to live in ways which benefit others, helping those around us lead healthier and happier lives. Buddhist practices such as mindfulness, understanding our feelings, and seeing the roots of our thoughts help us to act with care, and we're happier as a result. Through our practice we cultivate qualities that resonate with an enlightened mind rather than block its development.

When we transform ourselves in this way we can also begin to consider what we might bring to our relationships with others: open-mindedness, compassion, steadfastness, respect, courtesy, modesty and other conscientious ways of being. Through these, we create fewer reasons for others to have to wrestle with their own hindrances: pride, attachment, aversion, and fear. Our sobriety and awakening create conditions for the sobriety and awakening of others. The gifts we receive from our own practice, by their very nature, begin to extend to others, and we can move with others in loving community.

Shantideva:

And catching sight of others, think
That it will be through them
That you will come to Buddhahood.
So, look on them with open, loving hearts.

Sharing the Prepared Mind

Practicing the Paramita of Patience

Paramita is a Buddhist term which means “perfection,” a noble characteristic of an enlightened being. There are several different lists of paramitas, but they share many of the same qualities: patience, generosity, discipline, enthusiasm, meditation, and wisdom.

Paramitas offer ideas which run parallel to the Eightfold Path, with its presentation of wise ways of being. Like the elements of the Eightfold Path, paramitas are more inspiration than fixed rules. The paramitas of patience and generosity, especially, invite us to practice gentleness and ease in our lives, which then manifest in our relations with others.

The paramita of patience can be very helpful when working with hindrances like anger and irritation. Shantideva identifies anger, of all the hindrances, as the most destructive:

> No evil is there similar to anger,
> No austerity to be compared with patience.
> Steep yourself, therefore, in patience —
> In all ways, urgently, with zeal.

Again, however, we need to take a moment to disentangle our emotions from our actions. It’s not that we shouldn’t experience anger, for instance, or even consider anger to be bad in some way. Like any emotion, anger is a natural response to conditions.

But—and this is the vital point—it’s what happens next that is important. What does our anger in response to a particular event or circumstance tell us? Does it help us to clarify what we’re objecting to? Does it reveal hurtful impulses in our response?

Our perceptions create feelings, such as anger, which in turn create thoughts and then actions. Our feelings and thoughts are important. We should explore and understand them, each in their own nature as well as in relation to one another. We can feel them in our spirit and in our bodies, and then, with practice, allow them to dissipate, as we let go our hold of them.

But along the way, it’s in our impulse toward action where we need to be especially aware. Our perceptions and feelings become thoughts which can move us into action, and it’s here where we can be either skillful or unskillful. My teacher, Teshin Matthew Sweger, speaks of a process of “adaptive action,” wherein we consciously assure that our actions align with our intentions. In recovery, my intentions are clear. First, to stay clean by engaging and supporting my own sobriety and awakening. And second, to engage and support the sobriety and awakening of others. Actions I take to support these intentions are skillful. Actions I take which do not support my intentions are unskillful.

Leading Toward Patience

A Different Way to View Discomfort

Disciplines of the mind can help us gain relief from our afflicted emotions. Even so, we often need to deal with difficult energies that continue to crop up day to day.

Even with a practice of patience, we still experience suffering thoughts. Indeed, our emotional pain can reveal itself more clearly even as we work to grow into a more patient presence. Shantideva tells us to not be discouraged by this discomfort, however.

Suffering also has its worth.
Through sorrow, pride is driven out
And pity for those who wander in samsara;
Evil is avoided, goodness seems delightful.

In this passage, Shantideva points out what at first may not make sense: that there can be value in suffering. As a practice of patience helps us to see our suffering thoughts more clearly, we can know them as simply part of the human condition.

We experience pain even as we work toward a more awakened way of being. Gratitude for the chance to practice with our suffering can help us be courageous in our efforts, even though we know that we suffer like all beings, and that we will always have work to do. Rather than feel prideful in our practice, we develop compassion toward ourselves and others who still "wander in samsara," the suffering of afflicted emotions.

In this way, Shantideva tells us, we avoid the "evil" of thinking only of ourselves, even as we live into the "goodness" of seeing suffering as a reality we share with all beings. Suffering is an opportunity to develop compassion and patience into a continued presence in our lives.

Practices:

- Make an honest assessment of the things you find uncomfortable in your life. Which of these are things that you may simply need to accept as reality? Ongoing pain from an injury, the loss you feel from a relationship now ended, the remorse you have from hurting someone you care about; sometimes we carry a lot of resistance to things we can't actually change. Remember that these kinds of things are part of being human; everyone has things like this which are difficult. Rather than resisting these things, or viewing them with resentment, work consciously to surround them with a sense of compassion and self-care.
- The first of the Buddha's Four Noble Truths reminds us that all beings suffer in one way or another. Knowing that you are not alone in your life's discomfort, work to remember the suffering of others and to practice compassion toward all beings, known and unknown to you. Consider saying this short gatha as a prayer of support: "May all beings everywhere, all those plagued by sufferings of body and mind, be at ease."

Understanding That Life is Complex

Life is complicated; that's a given. People often do things we don't like, and situations don't always turn out the way we want them to. Sometimes we're just not sure what's going on. This can lead us into the reactive patterns of our feelings: irritation, anger, jealousy, sadness, and disappointment. When this happens, it can be helpful to remember life's complexity, and that the actions of others can be based in complex feelings, just like ours.

Our speech and actions toward people and situations are shaped by our response to our own feelings. None of us wake up in the morning intending to be angry or disappointed. As we go through the day, however, we meet with causes and conditions which lead us into swift streams of reactivity. In all this complexity, we need to keep sight of two simple realities. The first is that each moment offers us a chance to practice with patience and understanding. The second is that each moment follows the one before it, and precedes the one that follows.

Even the most twisty line is made up of a series of points, one after another. So, too, are our lives a series of moments, each colored by the one before it, each an influence on the next moment to come. The feelings which hold sway in one moment are rooted in how skillfully we've worked with our feelings in the moment before. And what happens next is rooted in how skillfully we work with our feelings right now, in this moment.

Practices:

- Learn to practice acceptance for the complexity of life. Know that some things are beyond your control. The actions of others, accidents which slow us down in traffic, experiencing uncertainty in different situations, these and more are experiences we all share. We suffer when we cling to the desire that something will just stop or go away, or to our need to control a situation. Observe desires such as these and develop a practice of non-attachment to them. Practice taking good breaths in moments of difficulty and remember two things: that there are some things you can't control, and that whatever it is you're seeing as an obstacle won't last forever.
- When in a situation which feels beyond your control, mindfully observe your reactive feelings and name them. Are you irritated or angry? Disappointed? Fearful or worried? Remember, observing your feelings and creating space around them can help loosen their hold on you. Consider using a gatha, such as "This feeling of (anger, fear…) is a response to my experience. Breathing in I bring compassion to my (anger, fear…). Breathing out I calm my (anger, fear…)."
- Learn to observe how your feelings in one moment can color the next moments to come. Practice a sense of self-compassion when you find yourself perpetuating difficult feelings. Practice gratitude when you find that practices of breathing and mindful observation help your feelings to become more beneficial.

Developing Tolerance for the Actions of Others

Sometimes we run into people who seem hell-bent on hurting others. Some people are abusive, some are mean, and some just don't care. I've met enough that I have come to know the traits they have in common, and I can see them coming a mile off.

I was in an emotionally abusive relationship when I was younger, and I used to burn myself up in resentment each time I had a negative experience with this person, which was almost every time I saw her. More than anything, I wanted her to not treat me the way she did. I was always shocked and hurt by her behavior, and always resentful and angry in return.

One day I realized that what she was bringing to our relationship was all I was going to get, that there wasn't anything else. I suddenly knew I didn't need to be shocked by her behavior anymore, which gave me an opening to let go of my reactive anger and hurt. I was first reading Shantideva around that time, and this made a lot of sense:

If those who are like children
Are by nature prone to injuring others,
What point is there in being angry —
Like resisting fire for its heat?

I was able to build a tolerance to this person's behavior. Not an acceptance, just a tolerance which helped me to not react so strongly to it.

Different Forms of Patience

Most people, though, aren't hurtful by nature, but simply unskillful. Sometimes in dealing with other people, we just have to give each other a break. Most people in my experience are pretty decent. They make mistakes, but we all do. They can be conceited and arrogant, but so can I. They get angry, but everyone does. Regardless, I believe that most people are basically well-intentioned and caring. Even if they make mistakes, they usually come around to make things right. Shantideva helped me with these folks, too:

And if their faults are fleeting and contingent,
If living beings are by nature wholesome,
It is likewise senseless to resent them —
As well be angry at the sky for having clouds!

If we believe that people are basically good by nature, Shantideva asks, then why get angry with them over faults which are "fleeting and contingent" on circumstances they may not be able to control?

Sometimes people are abusive by nature, but sometimes they're just having a difficult moment. Either way, their behavior can show us our own reactive nature, and help us to deal with our experience more skillfully. Their actions can spark a patient response in us, where we can find a better way forward.

Again, sometimes we just have to accept that things are true, that they are real, and that we may not be able to change them. This is where the paramita of patience offers two important practices: forbearance, and the endurance of hardship.

Forbearance is to bring a sense of tolerance toward the actions of others. This is different than condoning someone's behavior. To tolerate something is not to just allow it to happen. Instead, tolerance can be seen as a modification in your own response to what someone else has done. Shantideva encourages us to recognize when the behavior of another is simply part of their nature. We may not like what another person does or says, we may even choose to disassociate ourselves from them, but we don't need to harbor suffering thoughts about it such as resentment, sadness or anger.

Enduring hardship asks us to be patient in spite of what's happening, and to work with the situation constructively. Few things change by themselves, especially things that are difficult. To practice endurance in hardship is to work to change a situation as we can, to keep going, and to address things with wise action and wise speech.

Practices:

- When faced with someone else's difficult behavior, practice evaluating what is really going on. If what is happening is uncharacteristic for that person, consider the role of patience in choosing to give them a pass, so to speak. We all make mistakes.
- On the other hand, if someone's behavior is consistently difficult, remember that to react against them may be as useless as "resisting fire for its heat." Instead, breath mindfully, be aware of your feelings and practice non-attachment and release. Don't be afraid to stop an interaction, or even break off a relationship if you feel that's what you should do. But do it with compassion, for yourself and for the other person. Do it with mindfulness of the need for your own right action and practice of kindness.

❀

Practices in Word

As our recovery deepens, we begin to find faith in possibility… that we are capable of goodness; that there is hope in sobriety and spiritual development; and that we are at our best when we help others as well as ourselves.

❀

When we work in Buddhist recovery, considering the different aspects of the Buddha's Eightfold Path can offer real insight into more skillful ways of life. A practice of right speech, in particular, can help us not only to avoid conflicts, but to solve them equitably and with care.

But when dealing with others, it can seem unclear just what kind of speech is "right." What is called for in one situation may be out of place in another. What is acceptable to one person may be offensive to someone else.

Generally, we can always do well by speaking in ways that fall within a practice of loving kindness. More specifically, though, we can find guidance by simply taking the word "right" and replacing it with "upright." Upright speech is to speak in accord with the situation, to speak honestly and completely, and with consideration for the mutual benefit of everyone involved. Practicing upright speech is to speak with a commitment to bringing compassion and care into our interactions with others.

Practicing Skillfully with Divisive Speech

Upright speech needs to be part of our practice as a Buddhist and as people in recovery. What do we practice in relation to speech? Two things, really: our choice of words and, then, an observation of how what we are saying is received by others.

As far as our choice of words, we should consider whether our speech is skillful, meaning whether or not it is helpful and beneficial to others and to the situation. For our speech to be skillful, to truly practice upright speech, we need to abandon four things: false speech; speech which divides people from one another; slander, gossip, and hearsay; and harsh or abusive speech.

Some of the best wording regarding upright speech comes from the precept on speech as worded in Thich Nhat Hanh's Order of Interbeing:

> *Aware of the suffering caused by unmindful speech and the inability to listen to others, I am committed to cultivating loving speech and compassionate listening in order to relieve suffering and to promote reconciliation and peace in myself and among other people.*
>
> *Knowing that words can create happiness or suffering, I am committed to speaking truthfully using words that inspire confidence, joy and hope.*
>
> *I am determined not to spread news that I do not know to be certain and not to utter words that can cause division or discord. I will practice right diligence to nourish my capacity for understanding, love, joy and inclusiveness and gradually transform the anger, violence and fear that lie deep in my consciousness.*[2]

Practices:

Thich Nhat Hanh's precept offers fine aspirations, but it may take us time to live into them. Along the way, we

can develop an honest practice of observing the effect of our speech on others. There are five questions we can practice asking ourselves as we observe our efforts toward upright speech. You may have heard them before:

- Is what I am saying true? Am I spreading something that is not true, or using my speech to gain advantage?
- Is now the right time and place for me to say this? Am I being considerate of the needs of others?
- Is what I'm saying gentle and kind? Is my manner of speech causing a difficult response?
- Are my words helpful, or are they meant to be hurtful?
- Is my speech coming from a mind of goodwill? What are my own motivations?

An Expanding Base

Practicing With Bodhicitta

Of course, we need some structure to support us as we work to develop all of this. For some of us, practicing upright speech and the mind states which support it can involve a fundamental reorientation of our patterns of behavior. How do we really move ourselves into this place of honest observation and kind consideration for others? How do we abandon the heat of greed, hatred and delusion which can color our speech? Buddhism teaches that we each have the nature of the Buddha inside ourselves. If that's so, how do we find it, and how do we come to act from it in our lives?

One thing to think about is the idea of generating something called bodhicitta, which can be thought of as having a completely open heart and mind. Put simply, bodhicitta is the wish to aid our own spiritual growth by having compassion for others, and working to help them in their own spiritual development. Through compassion we work to create causes and conditions which are beneficial for others, conditions in which others can live for their own betterment *and* for the well-being of those around them.

This may seem a little chancy, though. We often have to deal with people with whom we've had difficult times. People who have hurt us. People we may not trust. Pema Chodron calls bodhicitta a soft spot, where our vulnerability can cause us to be as tender as an open wound. But we can take heart in bodhicitta, she tells us, because its energy is a reflection of our own ability to love, even in the face of adversity.

This is big stuff, and you may not be comfortable with it. Still, if you've been to Buddhist-oriented recovery meetings, like Recovery Dharma or Refuge Recovery, you've surely done a loving kindness meditation where we extend good wishes even to people we don't care for. The idea of bodhicitta simply takes things one step further.

With bodhicitta, we recognize that our words and actions matter; that working on our sobriety and awakening is not just about helping ourselves, but that at the most basic level it's about helping others. Not simply because helping others is the right thing to do, but because helping others is itself a life of clarity, sobriety and awakening. Service to others is sobriety and awakening in action.

With bodhicitta, we live with an open heart and mind. Not causing harm, benefitting others, developing patience, using upright speech; with bodhicitta all of these are no longer actions that we choose, but the natural result of our hope to care for others—the reflection of a life lived in compassion. Again, Shantideva tells it perfectly:

> For sentient beings, poor and destitute,
> may I become a treasure ever plentiful,
> and lie before them closely in their reach,
> a varied source of all they might need.
>
> May I be a guardian for those without protection,
> a guide for those who journey on the road.
> For those who wish to cross the water,
> may I be a boat, a raft, a bridge.
>
> May I be an isle for those who yearn for landfall,
> and a lamp for those who long for light.
> For those who need a resting place, a bed.
> For all who need a servant, may I be their slave.
>
> May I be the wishing jewel, the vase of plenty,
> a word of power, and supreme healing.
> May I be the tree of miracles,
> and for every being the abundant cow.
>
> Like the earth and the pervading elements,
> enduring as the sky itself endures,
> for boundless multitudes of living beings,
> may I be their ground and sustenance.
> Thus for every thing that lives,
> as far as are the limits of the sky,
> may I provide their livelihood and nourishment

Until they pass beyond the bonds of suffering.[3]

This is the heart of bodhicitta, the heart of service. And even if we can't yet live into it fully, any movement toward this goal is a reflection of our own growth into the ability to help those around us.

Practices:

We all sometimes feel that other people are dis-respecting us, or harming us in some way. Often, this is based in our own sense of self-importance, a feeling that seeks out happiness for ourselves above all others. It can be easy to be filled with pride, and to act against others who don't go along with our ego-based desires.

Shantideva gave us a practice known as "exchanging self for others," where we let go of our self-cherishing thoughts and learn to value others as much as ourselves. We're encouraged to realize that the labels we apply to others—good, bad, friend, foe—often come from our own perceptions and feelings, rather than an objective understanding of other people and their actions. As a result, we can interpret an unpleasant experience as actual harm being directed at us, and we begin to consider other people as dangerous to our well-being.

- When you're in a difficult interaction, mindfully observe the emotions you're experiencing: anger, attachment, dissatisfaction, jealousy, pride, ill will. Recognize that these spring from your own perceptions of another person's intent, and that your perceptions may or may not be correct. Consider how you may be clinging to your own sense of self- importance, and how your valuing of self over others may be preventing you from valuing the presence and worth of someone else.

The next time you are in a difficult interaction with someone, practice reciting a gatha such as this: "My thoughts of self-importance are causing me to suffer hard feelings and thoughts. This person is helping me by reminding me of this, and giving me an opportunity to practice upright speech with them. I offer this person gratitude."

- The practice of *exchanging self for others* is to meditate on realizing the suffering of others and giving them happiness in return. When we deepen our practices of loving-kindness, compassion, and altruism, a sense of responsibility to be of help to others is revealed.

In meditation, visualize the hardship and suffering of others with your in-breath. Bring this suffering into your own self-cherishing mind and remember that suffering is a state of being we share with everyone. With your out-breath, visualize giving happiness and care not only to the person you are with but to everyone. Consider using a gatha such as this: "May my self-cherishing mind be released by understanding the suffering of others. May all beings receive wisdom and happiness."

- Engage a daily recitation of Shatideva's poem "For sentient beings, poor and destitute…" There are many lofty aspirations here. Consider the people and situations in your life. How might you be a "guardian" and a "guide" for those around you? How can you be a "light" and a "resting place" for people in need? How might you bring "supreme healing" to difficult situations? Each day, after you recite the poem, think about people and situations you have encountered in recent days, or are likely to encounter in the next few days. How can your speech and actions bring these aspirations to life?

The Three Refuges

Another thing to consider is the helpful strength of taking refuge in Buddha, dharma, and sangha. As our recovery deepens, we begin to find faith in possibility: that we are capable of goodness, that there is hope in sobriety and spiritual development, and that we are at our best when we help others as well as ourselves. But, as I said earlier, we need a structure of support to both find and actualize these in ourselves, an anchor to keep us from floating away in a sea of uncertainty. In Buddhism, the most basic structure of all is taking refuge. "I take refuge in Buddha, I take refuge in dharma, I take refuge in sangha."

Some people are uncomfortable with this idea. When we think about the word refuge, it's usually in the context of *seeking* refuge, like when we're faced with danger, or in need of protection. We think about having to find a safe place, and that can leave us with an odd feeling. Is the Buddha somehow larger than me, bigger than me, going to save me? Is the Buddha *able* to save me? Do I *want* the Buddha to save me?

It turns out that these questions aren't really relevant, because they're not what the teaching of refuge is about. Most Buddhists consider the idea of "taking refuge" not so much as seeking a safe place, but rather as a decision about what we choose to rely on. Refuge is about what we look to as a source of strength and example; what we value as helpful in our lives; what we trust and believe to be true.

Taking refuge is about taking a moment to discover qualities within ourselves that are attuned to the Buddha's path. Taking refuge is not an act of reverence, nor is it a position of weakness. That's not what it's about. If I had to put a name to it like that, I would probably choose to say that it's an act of respect.

But it's more than that, too. Taking refuge can help us find the life of the Buddha, dharma, and sangha within ourselves. When we really come to understand this, to feel Buddha, dharma and sangha as lived realities, they can help us in dealing with the circumstances in our lives.

Taking refuge doesn't make our problems go away. But by deciding to rely on the example of the Buddha, the wisdom of his teachings (the dharma), and the help of those around us (the sangha), we find that we are able to transform our response to life's hardships.

Jeffrey Shugen Arnold, an American Buddhist teacher, wrote that "Taking refuge involves taking a leap forward with a deep sense of trust in our own basic nature.

Buddha, dharma, and sangha are the real activity of compassion that has been passed down through many generations. They point to how real people seek real truth in a particular time and place."[4]

I take refuge in Buddha.

The Buddha was a man who, in his compassion, worked to achieve a path by which we can escape suffering. He assumed no importance, no high station or holy differentiation. This is what I have achieved, the Buddha taught, and you can achieve it too. You, too, can be Buddha (an awakened one). You already are, he told us. You only have to see it.

To take refuge in the Buddha is to recognize reality, to acknowledge possibility, and to embrace hope.

I take refuge in Dharma.

The teachings of the Buddha represent a way of life, rather than a system of religious beliefs. Together, they form a philosophy where deeper understanding helps us see our own sobriety and awakening as a task which creates conditions supportive of the sobriety and awakening of others.

To take refuge in Dharma is to acknowledge the unity of life, to find value in a personal practice, and to embrace growth.

I take refuge in Sangha.

Sangha is the community of people with whom we practice. We can find comfort and companionship in the strength of those who walk the dharma and recovery path with us. Though practice is a solitary journey, we engage it in the company of others. We are not alone.

To take refuge in Sangha is to acknowledge the value of practicing with others, to know that we can exist in a structure of mutual support, and to embrace community.

For those of us in Buddhist-oriented recovery, there can be no doubt that taking the three refuges is in line with

our path. The Buddha himself made this clear by connecting the refuges to ideas we hold dear, the Four Noble Truths and the Eightfold Path:

> When ordinary people become apprehensive over something that seems foreboding, they often seek refuge in such places as mountains or parklands, as well as in some monastery, up some tree, or in some mausoleum. These refuges are not particularly of the highest quality, nor are they the most valuable.
>
> People cannot free themselves from human suffering by relying on such refuges. When people take refuge in the Buddha, as well as in the Dharma and the Sangha, then, by means of their wise discernment, they continually observe everything from within the Four Noble Truths, namely, being aware of suffering, being aware of how suffering accumulates, being aware of how suffering is transcended forever, and being aware of the Noble Eightfold Path. Taking this refuge is to take the most excellent refuge; it is the one to be most valued. Without fail, it is by means of taking refuge in this way that we can rid ourselves of suffering.

Practices:

Finding strength and guidance in Buddha, dharma and sangha is a valuable structure for our practice. It reminds us of what we have chosen: a teacher we trust, ideas which touch our hearts, and others who share the same path.

More important, however, is the action of taking refuge itself, of reciting the three refuges aloud with conviction. Many people recite the refuges before or after meditating. Some say them first thing in the morning, or before going to sleep. A teacher of mine, Josho Pat Phelan, shared that she recites the words Buddha, dharma, sangha, in time with her steps as she walks.

- Find a time each day when you can be alone to recite the refuges, perhaps before you meditate, or while lighting a candle at a home altar. While different versions of the refuges can be found, you might consider these, as used at the North Carolina Zen Center:
- I take refuge in Buddha, and resolve that with all beings I will understand the Great Way whereby the Buddha seed may forever thrive.
- I take refuge in Dharma, and resolve that with all beings I will enter deeply into the sutra-treasure whereby my wisdom may grow as vast as the ocean.
- I take refuge in Sangha, and in its wisdom, example, and never-failing help, and resolve to live in harmony with all sentient beings.
- Koshin Paley Ellison of the New York Zen Center for Contemplative Care likens Buddha, dharma and sangha to “freshness,” “receptivity,” and “connection.” In an interview with the Wisdom Podcast, he asks us to consider our “activities of refuge.” In other words, to consider ways in which your practice keeps your spirit fresh, helps you to be receptive to others, and to speak and work to create and maintain community.

We Don’t Always Get it Right

Repenting Wrongdoing

We all do things which hurt others, either intentionally or through our own carelessness or negligence. If we’re living with awareness of the needs of others, however, it’s not hard to know when we’ve made a mistake.

When we do cause harm, the first step in making it right is to be truthful with ourselves. Josho Pat Phelan wrote, “Recognizing wrongdoing, knowing wrongdoing in your heart, is waking up to what we are actually doing.”[5] Reb Anderson, another zen teacher, adds "Confession of wrongdoing is an act of awakening.”[6]

In recognizing wrongdoing we may feel doubt, remorse, even shame. These are difficult feelings which challenge our sense of well-being, but it’s our honest self-recognition of wrongdoing that can bring us back into balance.

Living with a daily practice of mindfulness offers our best chance to recognize when something has gone off the rails. This could happen simply by hearing our own tone of voice, or seeing the reaction on someone’s face in response to our speech or actions. Or we might do a daily review of the interactions we’ve had with others, considering where we have been skillful, and where we have not.

Either way, a consideration of our own feelings at the time of our wrongdoing is key, both in understanding the root of our behavior and in formulating a meaningful apology or amend. It’s only when we’ve been fully honest with ourselves about having harmed someone that we can do something to make it right in a way that matters. There is a gatha that I’ve found help-ful to recite:

> All my ancient, twisted karma
> From beginningless greed, hatred and delusion
> Born of body, speech and mind
> I now humbly repent.

There’s a bit to unpack here, I know. First of all, karma. Contrary to how karma is often defined, getting what you deserve, the word actually has a slightly different meaning. Karma is a Sanskrit word that means "action" or “doing.” In Buddhism, karma refers to actions which are driven by our intentions, which then lead to future consequences. *Intention* is the key here, not simply action.

Sometimes we do the wrong thing, say the wrong thing, even think the wrong thing without really meaning to. Sometimes our actions may be harmful, but our intention was not. We may still need to set things right, but that’s easier to do when we really didn’t mean to do harm.

But other times we indulge in our hurtful thoughts, or we mean to hurt someone with our actions or words. This is karma. It can stem from the most ancient moments of our lives, and it can definitely be twisted.

Greed is easy to miss, so is hatred, and they’re both easy to deny. Yet their recognition is essential in Buddhism and in Buddhist recovery. If you’re at all familiar with the Four Noble Truths, you’ve probably heard greed and hatred referred to as “clinging” and “aversion.” We may be able to tell ourselves that we’re not greedy, or that we’re not a hateful person. But I don’t know anyone who doesn’t have things or ideas that they cling to. And everyone has things they feel aversion toward, things that we just don’t like. This is the second of Buddha’s Four Noble Truths. The first truth is that there is dis-ease in life. The second is that this feeling, call it dukkha or suffering, is caused by our clinging to something that can’t last, or by trying to push something away while it’s still a present reality.

My teacher, Teshin Matthew Sweger, reminds us that we’re generally reacting out of a four-fold pattern: wishing we weren’t with someone, wishing we were with someone else, wishing we weren’t somewhere, or wishing we were somewhere else. Either way, we’re missing the present moment which, when you think about it, is the only time we can be happy. And if we’re not happy, others often catch the brunt of our discontent.

Delusion is a bit more nuanced. As we talked about before, one of the basic tenets of Buddhism is that all things exist within an interdependent state. No one thing, no one person, exists without the causes and conditions of other things and people that make their existence possible. Delusion is when we believe we are separate from others, that what we say and do doesn’t affect others, and that their words and actions don’t affect us.

The Buddha knew that this view is mistaken. So does modern physics. My hands and the computer I’m typing on are swapping electrons right now. When you get to the subatomic level, we find that there aren’t hard boundaries between objects—or between people. And yet we engage in greed, hatred and delusion. People do. I certainly do, and so do you. We always have… beginninglessly… and we express them through our bodies, our speech and our minds.

And so what do we do? We try to see when we go wrong, and to do better in the future. But we also get proud, and forgetful. There are plenty of times when I need to remember that I’m prone to unskillful behavior, to explore where it comes from, and to make amends. To repent is simply to express regret for what we’ve done. Repentance is a word that turns some people off. But as people in recovery, we *know* we’ve done things we need to come clean

about. Sometimes to just repent our wrongdoing is all we have left.

All my ancient, twisted karma
From beginningless greed, hatred and delusion
Born of body, speech and mind
I now humbly repent.

Practices:

- Develop an honest, fearless practice of recog-nizing your own wrongdoings. In AA we speak of doing a moral inventory. In Recovery Dharma or Refuge Recovery we write inquiries where we consider our actions toward ourselves and others. No matter what your system is, do it often and make amends when they are needed. Feeling remorse, repenting our wrongdoing, is a sign of maturity and strength. Saying "I'm sorry" is a compassionate gift.
- Consider a daily recitation of a repentance verse, the one used here or perhaps one you compose yourself. Recite it three times after meditation, or a daily consideration of your speech and actions.



Practices in Deed

A mind state of control is not stable, but a compassionate and patient practice of release can be.



Recognizing our karmic actions, their causes and effects. Retooling the way we think. Becoming more careful with how we speak. Repenting our hurtful actions and working to make them right. When I was in early recovery, I knew that something was going to have to give if I was going to get these done.

But what had to give? What was in my way? What's in the way for any of us? The answer is right there in the repentance gatha from the last chapter: our continued indulgence in greed, hatred, and delusion which lead us into unskillful behaviors, our twisted karma.

Now I know… we're just people. "We're clever but we're clueless," Jack Johnson tells us in a song. The good news is that spiritual practice, in our case Buddhist practice, can help us get a clue.

Can we get rid of greed, hatred, and delusion all together? Probably not. But, Jack Johnson again: "We're just one breath in a chain of thought,"[7] and I find that encouraging. We may not be able to release these things entirely, but at least we can begin to open our hands. One breath at a time, one realization after another, one change upon change.

The Mind of Renunciation

Releasing Self-Created Suffering

What it comes down to is being able to let go of behaviors and thoughts we know don't work for us. Things we've found to be unskillful in dealing with ourselves and with others. This letting go is renunciation.

We have confusion, anxiety, and pain in our lives. When we finally come to a place where we've had enough of the role we play in creating our own suffering, we learn to bring patience and compassion to our process of healing. This, in turn, gives rise to a mind of renunciation, to a *willingness* to let go of our attachments and the need to push things away. Only then can actual release happen; only then can letting go be realized.

Letting go of the need to control our experience is key to renunciation. When we practice non-attachment, not being shaped by clinging and aversion, we learn to be present with what's happening in each moment. This presence brings understanding, and understanding can bring the decisiveness of change.

Presence in the moment is the context of our efforts toward renunciation. Here and now is where renunciation happens. Presence creates a stable spiritual environment for the work of releasing our deeply held patterns of thoughts, words and deeds. A mind state of control is not stable, but a compassionate and patient practice of release can be.

Bowing to Buddha, Bowing to One Another

Bowing is a vital Buddhist tradition. All schools of Buddhism practice bowing in one form or another, and it's been part of Buddhist practice since the Buddha's time in northern India 2600 years ago.

Back then, people in the monastic community would do dozens, if not hundreds of prostrations every day. On special ceremony days, they would do up to 10,000 prostrations in a day, if you can imagine that.

But there can be a misunderstanding of what bowing is really about, especially here in America. People can be uncomfortable with bowing. It can make them feel like they're putting themselves into a subservient position, or engaging in an act of worship.

The good news is that in Buddhism, bowing is not about those things. For us, bowing is neither an act of reverence, nor an act of deference. To really understand why we bow, we have to look outside of that box.

The first thing that bowing does do is provide us an opportunity to contemplate our presence in the moment. It provides an opportunity for mindfulness, to use our body and our breath in the action of a bow as a point of engagement with the present moment.

Over the years there have many times when I've gone into the meditation hall at our local Zen temple at odd hours —early in the morning, sometimes late at night. I go in and I do prostrations, sometimes called floor bows. I recite the refuges, the four great vows, the pure precepts, and I intersperse prostrations between all of them. I was giving a talk about bowing to a Recovery Dharma group a few years ago, and I told them about this. Afterward, someone asked me why. Why do I do this?

Part of the answer is as simple as what I said a moment ago: to bow is to engage with the present moment. Bowing offers a time when I can see my attachments and aversions as they crowd around me, and I practice using each bow to envelop these things in awareness, to open my clinging hands and let them rise and fall.

It's important to have moments like this. It's important to create moments like this. It's difficult to be disingenuous when we're bowing. It's difficult really to be anything other than honest with ourselves in the moment of a bow.

I've often felt that prostrations are like a haiku, emerging in mindfulness and reflecting the moment, making space for awareness and a sense of contact with our Buddha nature, interdependent with all sentient beings. And this is a second way to consider the bow, as an expression of interdependence.

The Zen teacher Norman Fisher tells a story of his teacher, Dainin Katageri Roshi, who would mumble softly in Japanese as he bowed. Fischer, who was then Katageri's attendant, asked him what he was saying, and the translation was something like this, "The one who bows, and what is bowed to, are one by nature. The bodies of oneself and another are not two. I bow with all beings to attain liberation, to manifest the unsurpassed mind, and return to boundless truth."[8]

There is a metaphor in Buddhism which speaks of the gift, the giver, and the receiver as a way of demonstrating the idea of interdependence, the not-separate nature of things. The moment of offering a gift, of receiving a gift, and of the gift itself transferring from one hand to another is all one thing. There's not really a separation in that moment of action between the gift, the giver, and the receiver. It's infinitely interdependent.

So when we bow, when we make prostrations, it's not divinity that we're acknowledging. We know that Buddha was a person, like us. Rather, when we bow we recognize our own capacity to awaken, and the opportunity to experience the Buddha nature we share with others, the reality of non-duality, the oneness of existence.

That's what we're honoring with our bow, our own capacity for sobriety and awakening in connection with others. When we bow to Buddha, we do recognize the Buddha as someone who reached awakening, as someone who has gifted us with a teaching and an example, so bowing does have a certain amount of respect to it. But in Buddhism, to bow is not a power imbalance, because the bower, and the one who is bowed to, are not separate. It's like an exchange in which we recognize the importance of each being in the universe, and the interconnection that we share in the inherent field of Buddha nature.

A third way to consider bowing is as part of our practice toward the well-being of everyone. Norman Fischer tells us that a unique quality of bowing is its internal function. He writes: "Bowing is a mental training that helps us to cultivate an attitude of love and appreciation for the Buddha nature within ourselves, and to appreciate that same nature in others. Not their Buddha nature as opposed to our Buddha nature, but Buddha nature itself, that which we all share in common, and which the energy of Bodhicitta calls us to honor."[9]

A psychologist and Zen priest named Seth Siegal said, "The beauty of bowing practice is that it is Bodhichitta in motion." When we make prostrations, we offer support for the sobriety and awakening of others, finding our own way toward sobriety and awakening by supporting the sobriety and awakening of others. Bowing is the spirit of bodhicitta in motion, Siegal said. "In bowing," he goes on, "we bow to ourselves as part of everything. We see the smallness of our own egos, the vastness of being, and the way of awakening."[10]

Bowing is a mental training, Fischer tell us. In the bow we open our body and mind to the reality of interdependence and the compassion it engenders. We open ourselves in the bow to letting go of everything but the quality of compassion. Bringing our compassion out, making it big, fashioning it day by day, bow by bow.

Do we think about all of this each and every time we bow? Perhaps, in an indirect, telegraphed way. But I think all of this is better held in feeling, rather than thought. In presence, rather than a projection in time.

Bowing is a point of engagement with the moment, with the interdependence of life, and the promise of compassion. Bowing is really very simple: when we bow to someone, they just return the bow. "Bowing is mutual,"Kategeri said. "Just one bow, bowing back and forth."[11] Even one simple bow, with our hands together, is near to the heart of practice.

Practices:

- Take a moment in the morning to practice bowing. This might be as simple as putting your hands palm to palm and taking a few breaths while quieting your mind.
- Practice bowing as you recite your repentance gatha, a verse by Shanitdeva, or the three refuges. Standing with your hands palm to palm and bowing after reciting a mantra is a wonderful practice.
- Find a friend who would be willing to share a practice of bowing as a greeting. When you see one another, put your hands palm to palm and bow to one another in celebration of your friendship and connection. Consider introducing this practice to your recovery sangha.
- Find a website or a friend who can show you the practice of making full prostrations, or floor bows. Practice these as a physical engagement with the physical world, the moment, and your own mindfulness.

The Paramita of Generosity

Like patience, generosity is another of the paramitas, or spiritual perfections. Acting with generosity is tied directly to the idea of karma, or the spirit in which we act toward others. Remembering that we live in interdependence with all beings, it becomes easy to observe relationships of cause and effect—conditions which support the well-being of others or detract from it. With right understanding, the reality of our interdependence with others naturally develops into a desire for mutual support. In time, we come to an understanding of its inevitability as the natural order of things.

The American philosopher Ralph Waldo Emerson referred to this as the endless circulation of divine charity: "The wind sows the seed; the sun evaporates the sea; the wind blows the vapor to the field; the ice on the other side of the planet condenses rain on this; the rain feeds the plant; the plant feeds the animal."[12] So, too, can our actions nourish others.

Norman Fischer tells us that the practice of generosity can be a radical one. For some of us, this can mean a fundamental shift in the ways we interact with others. To be generous, we need to honestly assess the attitudes which guide us, their roots, and how our attitudes effect how we think, feel, and act.

But our attitudes are not fixed in place, Fischer tells us, and he encourages us to investigate when we feel unwilling to be generous with others. With a spirit of investigation, we can find what it is that blocks our generosity. We can study our feelings and thoughts, noticing when we are fearful, defensive, and protective of what we have. What if instead of these, we can begin to see that everything we have in life has been given to us by life itself?

Life always finds a way toward more life. So, too, does a generous spirit. Reb Anderson, an American Buddhist teacher, tells us that “Generosity responds with kindness to whatever turns up, including people and events we find challenging. Generosity is graciously receiving all aspects of our life.”[13] To perfect this response, sometimes we just have to get out of our own way.

Traditionally, there are three kinds of generosity, three gifts we might bring to others: material gifts, the gift of dharma, and the gift of fearlessness.

Material giving is self-explanatory, and is often the one we think of first. Gifts of food, money, clothing, medicine, shelter; the more we can offer, the better for everyone. Every gift we make, no matter how small, not only helps the recipient, but opens our own heart as well, leading us into a growing capacity of generosity.

At its most fundamental level, to give the gift of dharma is to give the gift of inspiration. When we discussed the idea of generating and dedicating merit earlier, we were really talking about the paramita of generosity. Buddhist practices have so much to offer to both our own well-being and the well-being of others. Patience, generosity, ethical conduct, loving kindness, compassion—these things are gifts in their very presence. You don’t have to be a Buddhist teacher to share the dharma. In living your life for your own health and for the benefit of others, you share the dharma simply by being with others. And you will inspire others to do the same.

The gift of fearlessness is a gift of love. When people feel loved, they feel safe and confident. When those around us know they matter to us, that we respect them and care for them, we surround them with the reality of love. It’s not that we can keep bad things from happening, but we can let others know that we are here to share their burden. That compassion and understanding, physical help, emotional support, and spiritual acceptance are gifts that we can offer freely.

Practices:

Can we appreciate the natural abundance that is inherent in life? When we practice generosity, we slowly begin to create a shift in our attitudes, both toward what we have and toward our relationship with others.

- Practice material giving at even the smallest levels. For instance, if I am splitting something with someone… a piece of cake, the rest of the coffee… I always offer the larger portion to the other person. Just this simple act opens the spirit of generosity in my heart.
- Begin to observe more closely how people are responding to you as you speak and act. Consider how generously offering loving kindness and compassion might change the ways in which others perceive you. Visualize how their response might look and feel in response to your kindness.
- Though it may feel awkward, look for moments when someone around you seems like they might be having a difficult time. They might be frustrated, tense, sad, or fearful. With compassion try asking people, even strangers, "Are you OK? How's it going?” Asking the question doesn't mean that you are offering an answer or solution to their problem. All it means is that you see their suffering and are offering a friendly, caring presence. Never underestimate the power of this gift!

Living an Ethical Life

The Paramita of Ethical Conduct

Ethical conduct is also a paramita and plays a vital role in our recovery work. Similar to the act of dedicating merit, actualizing ethical conduct in our lives begins with an act of radical imagination. If we believe that we each have Buddha nature within us, the inherent spark of an awakened life, and that we share that same nature with others, then we also can find an innate wish for the happiness and welfare of everyone, even if right now it may be buried way down.

This is where imagination can help. Exploring and practicing ethical conduct begins as an act of intention. At some point, we realize that we can live more uprightly, and we begin to consider how relieving that might be, how living an ethical life can help us reduce our own self-created suffering as well as the suffering of others. We begin to look inside to find this part of ourselves, to bring it forward, and to live it as best we can.

Precepts

Precepts were created by the Buddha as his group of followers, his sangha, hit snags in their social interactions. From his own sense of compassion and concern for their well-being, the Buddha created precepts as they were needed. In that light, we can consider that to practice Buddhist precepts is to practice the ethical life of the Buddha.

In his book Being Upright, Reb Anderson sees precepts as a “map of the Buddha mind” which forms when we understand and *feel* that all life is mutually supportive. From this insight, we begin to lean into our own suffering and the suffering of others, rather than turn away from it. And when we do, a practice of ethical conduct suddenly seems possible. In time, ethical conduct becomes desirable and, finally, natural.

A Buddhist practice of ethical conduct is based in a practice of precepts and has three aspects: behavioral restraint, virtue, and fulfillment. First, of course, is behavioral restraint. At some point, we have to become convinced that we are hurting ourselves and others and work to just stop. This is the idea of renunciation, putting aside not just substance or process addictions, but also the unskillful behaviors which stem from them.

Second is a conscious development of virtue, working to develop positive personal qualities which we show through our conduct toward others. The development of virtue goes beyond restraining our behavior to building an inner passion for taking actions of goodness and care.

The third, and most developed aspect of ethical conduct, is simply to find fulfillment in helping someone else. We learn to love and help others without feeling the need to restrain our actions or to develop our virtue, but simply out of a sense of well-being in doing the right thing. As our practice of living ethically deepens, we naturally begin to expand love and care toward others as a way of living.

Practicing With Precepts as Ethical Conduct

There is a story about a Chinese monk who was called Bird’s Nest Monk because he often meditated in the tops of tall trees. One day an important man, a government official and well-known poet, was walking home when a sudden storm came up. The man was in the area where the monk lived and, looking up, he saw the Bird’s Nest Monk in the uppermost reaches of a tree, meditating while swaying violently in the wind and rain.

When the official saw the monk, he feared for his safety and called up, “Friend, it doesn’t seem safe for you up in that tree."

The Bird’s Nest Monk replied, “Nor does it seem safe for you down on the ground."

The governor said, "I am a well known and important man in this province. I don’t see what danger there is for me here."

The Bird’s Nest Monk responded, "Then, sir, you don’t know yourself very well. When passions burn and mind is unsteady, this is the greatest danger."

The man then asked, “Friend, can you tell me the heart of Buddha’s teaching?" and the Bird’s Nest Monk recited a verse, "Renounce all evil. Practice all that is good. Keep your mind pure. Thus all the Buddhas taught."

When the governor heard this, he was not impressed and said, “Any child of three years knows that."

To which the Bird’s Nest Monk replied, "Any three-year-old child may know it, but even an eighty-year-old man cannot do it.”

Renounce all evil.

Practice all that is good.

Keep your mind pure.

Thus all the Buddhas taught.

These lines are old. They feel broad, like the parts of the Eightfold Path, and they’re easy to feel intuitively. As

Mahayana Buddhism developed from the older Theravada traditions, the verse underwent a change that reflected the shift from the ideal of personal perfection toward awaking into the oneness of all beings, of interdependence as an expression of Buddha nature. (In recovery, this is the shift toward finding our own sobriety and awakening through creating conditions that encourage the sobriety and awakening of others.) The last line of the verse was dropped, and the third line was rewritten:

Renounce all evil.
Practice all that is good.
Save the many beings.

I know there are some heavy words here (evil, good, save) that may be open to interpretation. So, let's try this instead:

I vow to be free of self-clinging.
I vow to engage in wholesome conduct.
I vow to help others along their path to awakening.

Or this:

I vow to refrain from harmful conduct.
I vow to cultivate beneficial conduct.
I vow to benefit all beings.

Either way, what we're talking about is personal transformation and engaging in compassionate actions toward ourselves and those around us.

As time went on, these three Pure Precepts were developed into a number of longer lists, including the five precepts we are familiar with in dharma-based recovery literature:

- Avoid taking the life of another living being, or causing harm to ourselves or another living being.
- Avoid taking what is not freely given, or stealing.
- Avoid causing harm through our sexual conduct, and be aware of the consequences and impact of our sexual activity and desire.
- Be honest, not lying or using speech in a harmful way.
- Avoid the use of intoxicants and intoxicating behavior that cloud our awareness.

As Mahayana traditions grew, another list of precepts came into use. Some refer to these as the ten Grave Precepts, though I prefer a name I've been hearing more recently, the ten Clear Mind Precepts.

While the three Pure Precepts are sensible, general ways of considering our behavior on the whole, the Clear Mind Precepts address specific ways in which we act and react; they're geared to our ways of being, and are meant to be practiced in our community with others.

- Cherish life and do not kill.
- Cultivate generosity and do not take what is not offered.
- Cultivate honest, caring relationships and do not misuse sexuality.
- Be truthful and do not tell lies.
- Maintain clarity and do not misuse intoxicants.
- Speak kindly and do not speak ill of others.
- Encourage others to abide in their awakened nature and do not praise self at the expense of others.
- Be generous and supportive of others and do not be possessive.
- Be understanding and loving and do not harbor ill will.
- Cultivate awakening, the path of awakening, and the community that takes refuge in awakening; and do not disparage the three treasures of Buddha, Dharma, and Sangha.

Later, the notion of interdependence was expanded into the idea of dependent co-arising—the idea that things rise into existence because conditions come together which allow them to rise. *This* is because *that* is… *these* cannot come into being without *those*… *this* creates conditions which allow for *that*, *that* creates conditions which allow for *this*. In practical terms, all of us are linked together in a state of mutual support and mutual reflection.

Thich Nhat Hanh wrote that things arise in dependence upon different causes and conditions, noting that nothing exists as a singular, independent thing. If this is really the case—that we are each inextricably linked in the most basic, vital ways—then that connection calls us into compassion, into a desire to work toward the enlightenment of all by living into the actions of the precepts themselves.

In practicing precepts, we resolve our own suffering by helping others to resolve their suffering, by creating causes and conditions which help others to grow and flourish toward sobriety and awakening. Because what do we do when a realization of interdependence calls us into compassion in action?

- We cherish life.
- We cultivate generosity.

- We form caring relationships.
- We speak truthfully.
- We maintain clarity.
- We speak kindly and respectfully.
- We encourage others to abide in their awakened nature.
- We act in generous, loving, and understanding ways.
- And we cultivate our own sobriety and awakening. We honor the path of sobriety and awakening while practicing in community with all sentient beings.

My coming into a sober, awakened state is linked to your coming into a sober, awakened state. Our sobriety and awakening are interdependently related. We can support one another best through acting ethically in our relationships, because when we do others don't experience reactive hindrances such as anger and doubt. Through ethical behavior, we give each other the gift of safety.

It's a lot to take on, I know. When I was first hearing about precepts, I felt that I couldn't necessarily uphold them. I don't always uphold them even now. But I work toward it. I practice. I try.

When considering precepts, when we practice them in our lives, a lot depends on our intention. I love the word *rouse* in this context. To rouse our intention. Not to *arouse.* The words are similar, and we sometimes use them interchangeably, but they have a slight difference in meaning. "To arouse" means to prompt, to provoke, or incite. Someone influences you and you respond: you're sexually aroused, or you're aroused to violence. To be "aroused" seems like something that happens to you, and which then has an outward manifestation.

To "rouse," on the other hand, feels like something that we do ourselves. We rouse ourselves from sleep into wakefulness; we get up. In working with precepts, Pema Chodren speaks of good intention as a thing we need to recognize in ourselves, and that when we rouse our intention into practice, that's more than half the battle.

But what I continue to wrestle with in the end, is that intention is not enough. We all know that it's not enough. It's beautiful, necessary, it's a strong and key foundational step, but it's not fully enough.

Precepts are sometimes worded as commitments. In the San Francisco Zen Center tradition, the first precept reads this way: "A disciple of Buddha does not kill but rather encourages life." In the lay ordination ceremony at the Chapel Hill Zen Center in North Carolina, however, the precepts are worded more strongly: "I vow not to kill. I vow not to speak falsely." Serious business.

What is the alchemy required for an intention to become a commitment? Or something even more than a commitment? This is where we come to the idea "living by vow."

A commitment is being dedicated to an idea or to an undertaking. But circumstances change, and so do our commitments. A vow, on the other hand, is more like a promise. A vow should not be subject to circumstance. It needs to be given from the heart, and it should inform our choices. A vow should guide how we live. But by what power does intention become vow? And how is a vow sustained over time and through the events of our lives?

Reb Anderson teaches that precepts need to be continually maintained because the conditions of our lives are constantly changing. The significance of the precepts, he tells us, can be different in different situations. It requires a lot of effort on our part to see where we are and how we're holding steady as things swirl around us. As I said, it's serious business.

We need sustained energy for this. We need energy to support our vows and allow them to guide us, not sometimes, but all the time, and in all places. Where does that energy come from? The presence of sangha is certainly a precious and supportive gift, but in the end the energy which fuels our efforts can't come from outside of us. It has to come from within, and that can be a difficult, even frightening idea.

In a dharma talk at the San Francisco Zen Center, Paul Haller said something which made sense to me: "Giving is participation in life." Maybe the energy in our practice of precepts comes from the practice of vow itself. Regarding vows, the Zen teacher Shōhaku Okumura wrote, "The body has no life without the vow. Vow illuminates the body in living, motivates us, enlivens us. The vow is our sense of purpose and meaning in life. It's the basic spirit behind everything we think, everything we choose, and everything we accomplish with this body in this lifetime."[14] Making a vow is not meant to be a burden. Rather, making a vow is a gift we give to others.

Can we live this way? Can we be as committed as this? Do we even want to be? It's a lot to live up to; it may even feel constricting. But here's an idea that fascinates me. As we move toward sobriety and awaking by serving the sobriety and awakening of others, the practice of precepts doesn't really restrict our liberty. After all, their wording is positive, their intention is healing: to cherish life, to be truthful, to be caring. Their living is positive: cultivating generosity, maintaining clarity. Living with vows gives us liberty from the suffering of our own preconceptions, interpretations, and judgements. When we practice in this way we liberate ourselves from our own constrictions, and we bring to others the conditions necessary for them to do the same.

Which brings me back to the three refuges, taking refuge in Buddha, dharma and sangha. We need strength and

commitment to live an ethical, precept-based life. Taking refuge is an expression of our belief and confidence in human goodness. In taking refuge, we affirm our commitment to working toward ethical behavior, and into actions of goodness and care.

It isn't enough to get what we want, or even need. To truly live by precepts is to commit to something more ambitious than this, a higher obligation and calling: to live with joy and love, justice, and concern not only for our own well-being, but for that of others.

You may have noticed that I've not mentioned the idea of "keeping" or "breaking" the precepts. Rather, I've used the phrase "living by precept." One might also say "living *with* precepts," for that's what we need to do in each moment. It's not a matter of keeping or breaking a precept. Rather, to practice with precepts is to become intimate with each precept as as we live our lives, to consider our actions and how the precepts apply to our thoughts, words and deeds. We need to be honest with ourselves, willing to learn, and willing to change as we realize the need. To be right or wrong in relation to the precepts is not the point. When we vow to live by precepts, we vow to consider our lives by each precept's spirit, and to be open to their guidance and growth.

Practices:

Precepts are less a set of rules and more of a series of guidelines through which we develop skillful behavior. It can be useful to know when our actions have gone against a precept, but without berating ourselves for having done something wrong. Rather, examine what's happened and consider how you might have acted differently. Consider this as a learning opportunity.

- Take time to really think about each of the precepts. Discuss them with a friend or mentor, or journal about your past experiences related to precepts. Consider how your addictions have affected your behaviors. Think about what a life in sobriety, guided by precepts might look like… what *your* life might look like.
- Have you ever made a vow? What was it, and what prompted you to make it? Take time to consider your past challenges and successes in "living by vow." What was helpful? What was hurtful? How did your indulgence with addictive substances and behaviors make the process more difficult?
- Take time to formulate a personal vow. Don't be hasty in the process. "I won't drink anymore," may not be enough. Sit with this in meditation, do some journaling, talk it over with a mentor or friend. Use your answers from the questions above to help you. When you decide, make your vow in the presence of a trusted friend who can support you in its fulfillment and your journey of living by vow.

The Four Immeasurable Minds

Tools for Living

We've been speaking all along about practicing from our hearts and minds for the well-being of others, even as we continue to attend to our own well-being. The Buddhist writer and teacher Alan Wallace tells us, "This is not self-negation, but rather self-contextualization."[15] We need to recontextualize ourselves away from an individually-oriented sense of existence into an understanding of our interdependence with other people—indeed, with all beings.

The question is, while it may be easy to understand that we exist in relation to others, do we really accept this reality *beyond* its face value? How do we translate our understanding of interdependence into an embracing, active, outward force? How do we find our our own well-being in relation to the well-being of everyone else?

When we remember that all of us live with sorrows and joys and that everyone hopes for happiness just as we do, then working for the well-being of others can become our reality. This is the energy of bodhicitta, a determination which turns our hope for the well-being of others into actions which can lead to just that.

Of course you might say, "Bodhicitta sounds all fine and well. I can see myself in interdependent relationships with others; I can develop bodhicitta. But actions which support the well-being of others… how can I know what those are? How can I know *how* to help someone, and when? After years in addiction, how can I know what's skillful behavior and what's not?"

The good news is that we don't need to know these things ahead of time. It's not actions that we need to learn, but rather a few simple principles which themselves become the tools we need to guide our actions.

The Four Immeasurable Minds, also called the Brahmaviharas, are a series of Buddhist virtues and meditative practices which help us to share our sobriety and awakening nature: loving kindness, compassion, shared joy, and equanimity. In acting from within these principles we lessen our own behaviors of clinging and aversion, removing the need for others to react to our resulting unskillful behaviors. When we act according to these principles in relationship with others, they become free of the need for their own reactive fear, doubt, anger, or sorrow. The Immeasurable Minds are the tools of bodhicitta.

Loving Kindness

We might think of loving kindness as simply a friendly way of being, and that's certainly a component of what it means. But more deeply, in Buddhism the essential nature of loving kindness is a yearning that someone be well and happy. We see this in the phrases of a loving kindness meditation:

May I be happy, may I be healthy,
may I be safe and at ease.
May you be happy, may you be healthy,
may you be safe and at ease.

Loving kindness represents a yearning for happiness and the need to be free of suffering—in relation to both self and other. In his book The Four Immeasurables, Alan Wallace tells us that this is the expression of our Buddha nature "wanting to realize itself like a seed that wants to spring into the sunlight."[16]

Our desire to be free of suffering; our recognition of the interdependence of our sobriety and awakening with the sobriety and awakening of others; our understanding of the need and ability of all beings to work for the betterment of one another—all of this is Buddha nature. It's a capacity we can all bring to life, something we share innately, whether or not we've realized it yet.

Practices:

Buddhaghosa, a 5th-century Indian Theravada Buddhist philosopher, asked, "What is the proximate cause of loving kindness?" The clear answer is when we observe a quality of lovableness in the person we are with.

- Bring to mind someone you care about, someone you find lovable. This could be a romantic partner, a child, a friend, even a teacher. Let it be someone, as Alan Wallace says, "for whom your heart will leap like a deer in the forest if this person were to walk through the door." Recognize the joy that this person brings you, and how your feelings of joy increase your desire to treat this person with kindness.
- Consider how this might be extended to a person who fills a neutral but recurring role in your life—a neighbor, a store clerk, or someone who is simply an acquaintance. Can you observe a lovable quality in this person? How does this change your feeling toward them? How does this change your relationship?
- As the barriers around your expression of loving kindness begin to fade, consider what might be a lovable quality in someone with whom you have difficulty, someone who has brought hostility into your life. Can you see something lovable in this person? Can you believe and understand that someone else might see

something lovable in them? Consider whether your own expression of loving kindness must depend upon the same being returned to you. If you can bring loving kindness to this person, consider how this effects your feelings toward both them and yourself. How does it affect your relationship with this person?

Compassion

Loving kindness is a longing for the well-being of oneself and others. More deeply, the nature of compassion is a yearning that everyone be free of suffering and the sources of suffering. Noting their interdependence, Alan Wallace points to loving kindness and compassion as fitting together like yin and yang.

But we need to be clear about the difference between loving kindness and compassion. With loving kindness, we are addressing potential. Loving kindness is a vision for the future, of the potential for future happiness, even if you or another person aren't happy now. Compassion, on the other hand, sees a person's suffering while it is happening, now, in this moment, and leads to a yearning for that person to be free from that suffering.

Practices:

There is a theme which runs through the practice of all of the Four Immeasurable Minds. Hear Shantideva: "As for myself, so for others. As I wish to be free of suffering, so do others wish to be free of suffering. I should eliminate the suffering of others *because* it is suffering, just like my own suffering. I should take care of others because they are sentient beings, just as I am a sentient being."

Shantideva's idea about why we should practice loving kindness and compassion is a radical one: that we should practice not for what we might gain in return, but because the suffering of others is as painful as our own. Compassion is that simple. It's a one-sided practice based in love and care.

- Let's look at this again: "As for myself, so for others. As I wish to be free of suffering, so do others wish to be free of suffering. I should eliminate the suffering of others because it is suffering, just like my own suffering. I should take care of others because they are sentient beings, just as I am a sentient being." Make a practice of saying this to yourself each morning. Plant the seeds of loving kindness and compassion in your heart and watch for opportunities for them to grow throughout each day.

Shared Joy

Shared joy, also called sympathetic joy, is a balance to loving kindness and compassion. These first two are based in a goal of transformation, that others may come into a state of well-being. The practice of shared joy, on the other hand, is to simply rejoice in the well-being of others as you witness it. Wherever you see happiness, take a moment to delight in it. This not only brings you joy, but encourages joy in others.

Practices:

- It's easy, of course, to do this with people you know, and I encourage you to practice shared joy with friends and family. If you wish to grow in this practice, begin to consider people around you who you do not know, but who you might observe in moments of happiness. Take time to reflect on their joy, that its energy is positive for the world, and be grateful for the chance to have been even a distant part of it.
- This practice is also possible with people you may deem to be unfriendly, or even hostile. When you see someone in that kind of emotional distress, bring to mind times when they may have been truly happy, a wedding, the birth of a child, when they were loved by their parents. Entering into an understanding of those moments can bring a sense of joy into your heart, and may in turn effect how you react to this person's difficult emotions. Your "remembrance" of their joy, and your expression of it, may help them to find peace. There are few greater gifts than this.

Equanimity

Simply put, the practice of equanimity is to value all things equally. But it's not simply a matter of neutrality or indifference. Rather, we might think of equanimity as a practice of impartiality in its best sense: bringing the same amount of care and concern to each person we meet. Alan Wallace tells us that equanimity is indispensable to the process of opening the heart completely. "Equanimity rounds out the other three immeasurables," he tells us, "and brings loving kindness, compassion, and shared joy to a profound state of balance[17]

Equanimity arises out of concentration. Concen-tration has the power to keep our minds secluded from hindrances such as worry and doubt, which can move our thoughts toward clinging and aversion. These clouded thoughts then manifest in our actions as fear, judgement, and uncertainty. Seclusion of our minds from the effects of the hindrances allows for balance, and for the mind to be unmoved in the face of our reactions to what happens around us.

In the Tibetan tradition, equanimity is considered to be the foundation of bodhicitta. The Mahayana Pure Precept “save the many beings” reminds us that our own existence is, by its very nature, related to others—your own identity formed within interdependence with others. With this in mind, the practice of equanimity is to cherish not just ourselves and those near to us, but the whole world. With equanimity we are called into more and deeper service. This is the motivation of bodhicitta: attaining the highest possible sobriety and awakening for the benefit of all beings.

Practices:

- Judgements are the near enemy of our practice of the Immeasurable Minds. Observe your perceptions to discover the ways in which you bring judgments, valuations, and interpretations to others. These can happen so quickly, and color our feelings so dramatically, whether they are correct or not. Be on a mindful lookout for these, recognize them when they arise, and work to establish instead the openness of a sense of “not-knowing."
- The Buddha said, “He who experiences the unity of life sees his own self in all beings, and all beings in his own self, and looks on everything with an impartial eye.” When you realize that you’ve made a judgement about someone’s character, motivation, or worth, consider that your view may be mistaken. In these moments, practice with a gatha such as this: “With mindful equanimity, I wake from the delusion that things should be as I want them to be."



Postscript

… and not let dust collect.



Huineng was the child of a government official in ancient China. When his father died, he and his mother were left in poverty. One day, while doing odd jobs to support his mother, Huineng heard someone reciting the Diamond Sutra and had a sudden insight. He began to travel in search of a teacher and eventually met Hongren, the Fifth Ancestor of Chan, or Zen Buddhism.

Hongren was looking for a successor and had proposed a poetry contest for his followers to demonstrate their understanding of his teachings. Hongren would pass down his robe and bowl to the winner of the contest, who would then become the Sixth Ancestor.

Shenxiu, Hongren's chief disciple, composed a poem but did not have the courage to show it to his master. Instead, he anonymously wrote his verse on a corridor wall in the middle of the night. In the morning, the other monks saw Shenxiu's poem and thought it wise:

The body is the bodhi tree.
The mind is like a bright mirror's stand.
At all times we must strive to polish it
and must not let dust collect.

When he read Shenxiu's poem, Hongren also declared it worthy, but noted that it did not yet show a full understanding of the "fundamental nature and essence of mind."

Two days later, Huineng heard Shenxiu's poem being chanted and went to the corridor, where he could also pay homage to the verse. After asking someone to read it aloud, Huineng composed his own verse, which Hongren immediate accepted as an expression of true wisdom.

I won't quote Huineng's poem here, for the difference between the two verses expresses the essence of Zen, which isn't really our topic. In fact, the fist verse, composed by Shenxiu, is more to our point.

His poem teaches that our body is the bodhi tree, the dwelling place of sobriety and awakening. The mind is like a stand which supports the mirror of wisdom. At all times, Shenxiu wrote, we must strive to polish the mirror and not let dust collect on its surface, obscuring our understanding. This is a valuable teaching for all of us in recovery… for anyone, really, but especially for us as we work to retool our intentions into right view, right action, right speech, etc.

The dust which obscures our progress toward sobriety and awakening is made of the hindrances of ill will, doubt, spiritual laziness, desire, and worry. The effects of these collect on our hearts and minds. Mindfulness is the cloth we can polish with, applying our practice to cleaning the mirror's surface and allowing our better selves to reflect more clearly into the world.

The postscript? A simple admonition: Wipe away. Wipe away.

❀

Thoughts on Meditation

The Blessed One said: "This is the direct path for the purification of beings, for the overcoming of sorrow and lamentation, for the disappearance of pain and distress…"

❀

Let's return to the poem Shenxiu wrote for the Fifth Ancestor. When talking about meditation, it offers a good deal of insight:

The body is the bodhi tree.
The mind is like a bright mirror's stand.
At all times we must strive to polish it
and must not let dust collect.

Life can be long, and circumstances hard, especially when we're tangled in addiction. Over time, the dust of our choices and actions settle thickly on our hearts as sadness, resentment, hopelessness, anger, and fear. Like grime on a window pane, our suffering hinders us from seeing our own inherent worth, and the ways in which we can find it again.

Shenxiu got a lot right. Our bodies can stand strongly upright if we care for them, and sobriety is our best first step. In that strength, our minds can reflect the kind of clarity that a spiritual life can provide. But dust will still collect, and so to my postscript: wipe away, wipe away… and meditation is our cloth.

There are three main types of meditation you might encounter in a buddhist-oriented recovery meeting, or that you might use for yourself in recovery practice: receptive meditation, directed meditation, and silent meditation. A receptive meditation is a guided meditation in which you receive ideas and practices. For instance, you might be encouraged to breathe in a certain way, to engage in a visualization, or to be mindful of different sensations. These meditations are often used for relaxation and to center ourselves, which can be very helpful, especially in early recovery.

A directed meditation, on the other hand, is when you generate certain thoughts, wishes, or qualities and direct them toward yourself and others. An example would be a loving kindness meditation, where you engage in an expressive process: "May I be happy. May I be peaceful. May I live with ease. May you be happy. May you be peaceful. May you live with ease." Directed meditations help us develop qualities such as loving kindness and forgiveness, and to express them toward ourselves and others. These are ancient practices and very helpful for people in recovery as we emerge from addictive behaviors into a place of engaged sobriety.

The first of the Four Noble Truths tells us that there is suffering, or dis-ease, in our lives. The second Truth is that this ongoing struggle has a cause—our own cravings and aversions. The realization of the third Noble Truth is that if our suffering has a cause, then we can work to *undo* that cause and lessen our suffering. We can work to walk back our clinging and aversion. We can crave less, and stop trying so hard to push things away. We can lessen our engagement with that struggle.

In order to do this well, however, we need to cultivate a different relationship with our feelings and thoughts, one born in observation rather than blindly following, in choice rather than reaction. We need to clean our minds of hindrances like doubt, anger, and fear, and then keep our minds clean in order for real change to happen. Mindfulness, purposeful awareness, is our most important tool in the process of cleaning the mind, and it's through silent meditation that we can develop this awareness most strongly.

In the practice of silent meditation, purposeful awareness becomes our fundamental quality of mind. We approach the sensations of our body, feelings, and thoughts with bare attention, learning to be with our sensations without judgment, or even the need for interpretation. Instead, we bring an accepting presence to our sensations, abiding with whatever comes with openness and curiosity. Developing this capacity for mindful awareness is vital in our recovery. A Buddhist recovery path can be transformational in deep and important ways, but for that to happen

we need to learn how to observe ourselves in the moment, and to skillfully meet our perceptions, emotions, and reactive thoughts.

The basis of silent meditation is a relationship with the breath. John Kabat Zinn, the founder of Mindfulness Based Stress Reduction, equates the breath as a bridge between the body and the mind. Using the breath, we develop the ability to bring mindfulness to the foreground, and to use it to examine our body, feelings, and thoughts in depth. This requires a subtle shift of attention, the movement of which is found in our simple inhalations and exhalations.

Silent meditation has a gentle ease to it—just keeping an awareness of the breath. I say this because it *is* that simple. But as anyone who has tried it knows, it can also be that hard. A helpful idea is in the meaning of the Pali word *sati*, as in *Satipatthana*, or *Anapanasati*, two sutras in which the Buddha gave direct instruction on meditation. As much as anything, *sati* means memory. But in terms of meditation, remembrance might be a good choice, or better still, simple presence.

Anapanasati meditation is a series of contemplations based directly in the breath. A*napana* refers to the movement of the breath, our inhalations and exhalations. *Sati* is presence, or bare attention. The word *Anapanasati*, then, is literally "breath attention," presence with the breath, a sense of oneness with the breath. With time and practice, we learn to be *of the breath*, part and parcel. Our breath and our body, our breath and our feelings and thoughts as one.

Breathing with full awareness encourages us to be aware of sensations in the body, feelings, and mind as they happen, to see them, to know them, and to disentangle ourselves from them. To practice with our sensations without attachment, and to prevent ourselves from spinning off into the suffering we often create around them, in whatever forms that might take: anger, sorrow, resentment, co-dependence, addiction.

The opening passage of the Anapanasati sutra does much to set the tone:

> I heard these words of the Buddha one time when he was staying in Savatthi. That night the moon was full. The Buddha, the Awakened One, was sitting in the open air, and his disciples were gathered around him. After looking over the assembly, he began to speak:
>
> Friends, our community is pure and good. Such a community is rare, and any pilgrim who seeks it, no matter how far she must travel, will find it worthy.
>
> Friends, the full awareness of breathing, if developed and practiced continuously, will be rewarding and bring great advantage. And what is the way to develop and practice continuously the method of Full Awareness of Breathing?
>
> It is like this: the practitioner goes into the forest, or to the foot of a tree, or to any quiet place, sits stably, holding his or her body straight, and practices like this: 'Breathing in, I know I am breathing in. Breathing out, I know I am breathing out.'

Simple, as I said. And hard, as anyone who has tried it knows. Can we breathe with awareness? Yes, we can. Will we get distracted? Yes, we will. Distraction in meditation is part of the game and we can't really blame ourselves for it, because thinking is what our brains are meant to do. The question, of course, is what we do in the face of distraction?

Ṭhānissaro Bhikkhu, a well known Thervadan monk and author, once wrote that when we follow certain trains of thought, we develop habits which naturally go along with them. When we react negatively to what we perceive as distractions, Ṭhānissaro asks, are we developing the thing our meditation is meant to develop? Are we developing a sense of calm, or are we developing turmoil? Are we developing the mental stability we seek, or are we developing a restlessness of mind?

This is tricky, because distractions can be persistently difficult. We've all felt distracted. We get settled into our meditation posture, our breath is growing calm, and then… the neighbor's lawnmower, your phone pinging, a video game the kids are playing. Or maybe it's something less dramatic, the sound of a ticking clock, a cough from the next room, a child's laugh from the street outside. Either way, you don't have to meditate for long before you experience distraction. It happens, taking us away from our awareness, pulling us away from our mindful concentration. And what can we do? Try to block it out? If you're like me, that becomes its own distraction and, in the end, a losing battle, usually leaving me frustrated and more distracted than ever.

In the Anapanasati sutra, the Buddha asked, "What is the way to develop and practice continuously the method of Full Awareness of Breathing?" Answering his own question, he said, "It is like this: the practitioner goes into the forest, or to the foot of a tree, or to any quiet place, sits stably, holding his or her body straight, and practices like this: Breathing in, I know I am breathing in. Breathing out, I know I am breathing out."

Simple, right? Yes. And no. This is the modern world, and we can rarely depend on finding this kind of solitude. A busy environment and a busy mind are not ideal settings for meditation, so we have to learn to handle whatever perceptions manifest during our practice. When we're distracted by what our senses perceive, we need to consider the platforms through which these perceptions present themselves, the "sense doors" of the eyes, ears, nose, tongue,

skin, and the workings of our mind itself.

This is where some people speak of the idea of restraining the senses, a process of sense restraint. But I find this phrase to be misleading. Restraining our sen-ses, not allowing their input to register, is not really possible; our nervous systems aren't wired for that. If you're like me, trying to block out distracting sensations becomes its own distraction, a losing battle that leaves me more distracted than ever.

Instead, the task is to learn to not *react* to sensorial perceptions in ways which pull us away from our concentration. With practice, we learn to register our sensorial perceptions without indulging our reactions to our perceptions, because it's in our reactions where our true distraction lurks. Instead, we learn to be within the realm of experience while stepping away from our reactivity to it.

Early Buddhist meditation practices encourage us to consider the idea of a gatekeeper at the doors of our senses—the eyes, the ears, the mind, etc. What if a sensation at any of these sense doors—a sight, a sound, or a thought—were met directly by the presence of mindfulness? What if a sensation were met at the moment of its arising, and understood for what it is, a sensation, just that and nothing more? Something which can divert our concentration, or not.

Our mindfulness, our present awareness, is the gatekeeper of our senses, a guard at our sense doors. We can use mindfulness to help us bear witness to our perceptions without grasping after our reactions to the input of our senses, including our thoughts. In this way, we understanding that our sensory perceptions are not distractions from our mindful awareness, but rather are part of our mindful awareness—not separate from our meditation, but at one with it. With mindful awareness, we allow our sensorial sensations to find a place in the background of our awareness, on the periphery of our concentration.

When I was in fourth grade, there was a train track near our house. When we first moved there, the sound and the vibration of the trains would keep me awake. But soon, my mind realized that these sensations weren't important and learned to filter them out. In the same way, in meditation our minds can learn to filter unnecessary sensations. With mindfulness we can consciously facilitate the process by handling our sensory input skillfully. This is the strength of mindfulness, its intended function in meditation—to stand as a gatekeeper at the sense doors, to filter the input of the six senses and help us keep our awareness on the breath. In that clarity, we can the engage our perceptions, feelings and thoughts in ways which lead to a more awakened life.

This is the strength of mindfulness, and part of its intended function in meditation practice. Standing as a gate keeper at the sense doors, our mindfulness doesn't keep things out, but rather helps things find their proper place. In this way we cultivate deliberate attention, engaging with the sensations of our experience, with the simple fact that they are happening, rather than with our own constructed interpretations of them.

There was a time when this seemed quite futile to me. When I was first meditating, distractions came at me almost without cease. I was practicing at the Denver Zen Center at the time, and I went to see the teacher about it.

"I can't stop thinking." I told him. "I swear, in a 40 minute period of meditation I have to stop and come back to my breath 100 times."

"Isn't that wonderful?" he replied. "Each time you mindfully return to your breath, you experience a moment of awakening. You're experiencing awakening 100 times during each meditation period!" That was such a relief, a simple change in perspective which helped me let go of my frustration over distractions, to reframe the way I looked at them.

I kept meditating, and I promise it has made a difference in my life. So please, don't depend on your intellectual understanding of Buddhist practices to find the personal transformation your sobriety deserves. If you don't already have a meditation practice, I encourage you to begin one today. Sit comfortably in a chair with your back upright. Let your eyes be level, closed or gently cast down. Rest your hands in your lap and just breathe. It's so simple, and the practice of a lifetime.

Glossary

Awakening To be "awake" in a Buddhist sense is to dwell in the present moment, free of the hindrances and delusion through which we create our own suffering.

Bodhicitta Bodhicitta may be translated as an "awakening mind." It's a spontaneous wish to attain enlightenment by being of service to others through compassion and care.

Buddha The Buddha, Siddhartha Gautama, was a man who was born in northern India nearly 2600 years ago. He travelled for 45 years after his enlightenment, teaching ideas based in three simple thoughts: that there is suffering, that there is an end to suffering, and that there is a path which leads away from suffering.

Buddha Nature Buddha nature is a central theme in Mahayana Buddhism, holding that everyone can attain the awakening of a Buddha. Buddha nature refers to a mind without greed, hatred or delusion. Buddha called this the natural and true state of mind. Existing within us like a seed, Buddha nature is the potential for all of us to attain liberation.

Eightfold Path The Eightfold Path is the fourth of Buddhism's Four Noble Truths. Each part of the path is designed to bring us to clearer understanding of what it means to live an upright life: right view, right intention, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness, right concentration.

Equanimity Equanimity is the steady and conscious realization of two important concepts in Buddhism: impermanence and no-self. These ideas point to the truth that all things are subject to change, and to the interdependent nature of all things.

Four Noble Truths The Four Noble Truths were the first teaching of the Buddha after his awakening: 1) that there is dis-ease and suffering in life, 2) that our suffering is created by our own clinging and aversion, 3) that there can be an end of suffering, and 4) that there is a path away from suffering, the Eightfold Path.

Five Hindrances The Buddha taught that there are five hindrances which prevent us from realizing our Buddha nature: anger, restlessness and worry, desire, doubt, and spiritual laziness.

Meditation The dictionary defines meditation as "a set of techniques that are intended to encourage a heightened state of awareness and focused attention." There are many forms of meditation in the world's spiritual traditions, including Buddhism. Within the context of sobriety, many people find meditation to be the most helpful when it develops mindfulness and encourages feelings of loving kindness and compassion.

Merit In Buddhism, merit is the positive karmic result of good intentions and actions. Merit is seen as an ethical force that can be directed toward something, often toward those who are suffering.

Mindfulness Mindfulness is the ability to be fully present in each moment, aware of where we are and what we're doing. With mindfulness, we learn to practice equanimity, not being overly reactive or feeling overwhelmed by what goes on around us.

Paramita The word paramita means "perfection" or "completeness" of character and understanding. Mahayana Buddhist traditions reference six paramitas: generosity, morality, patience, exertion, meditation and wisdom.

Renunciation On the surface, renunciation would seem to apply to giving up certain habits and things, such as consuming alcohol or too much media. While this *is* renunciation, a closer look reveals the need to release things at a deeper level, including feelings of greed, hatred, and the delusion of separateness from those around us. These deeper emotional/spiritual renunciations lead to more upright outward behaviors.

Repentance Repentance is a process of sincere self-reflection and self-discipline in relation to an upholding of precepts of ethical conduct.

Precept A precept is a specific characteristic of living an upright life. One example is "Not killing, but respecting all life." Another is "Not stealing, but taking only what is freely given." To undertake a precept-driven life is to dedicate oneself to a practice of right action.

Suffering The idea of suffering is a recognition that there are things in our lives which are difficult, ranging from discomfort with certain people or situations all the way to more extreme situation such as abuse, extreme illness, and death. In Buddhism, particular attention is given to our own reactions to events around us, and how our own thoughts and feelings form the base of our suffering.

Sutra A sutra is a written teaching of the Buddha. Taken together, Buddhist sutras represent one of the largest collections of humanity's spiritual teachings.

Taking Refuge In Buddhism, the idea of taking refuge in Buddha, dharma and sangha is not so much about seeking safety as making a decision about what we choose to rely on, what we value as helpful in our lives, what we trust and believe to be true. To take refuge is to discover qualities within ourselves that are attuned to the Buddha's path.

Theravada Theravada is the oldest of the major traditions in Buddhism, sometimes known as the “teachings of the elders." Its ideas emphasize personal awakening through one’s own efforts in meditation, following standards of ethical behavior and the teachings of the Eightfold Path.

Mahayana Mahayana Buddhism evolved in roughly the first century of the common era. Followers of Mahayana Buddhism also aim to achieve enlightenment through the teachings of the Buddha, but with an emphasis on helping all beings to awaken as well.

Vow A vow is a decision we make to uphold an ideal and to practice it at all times and in all places, regardless of the circumstances. Two examples are making a vow to deal with anger skillfully rather than to simply indulge in it, or to always be truthful.

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Joseph Goldstein
Mindfulness
The Experience of Insight
Larry Rosenberg
Breath by Breath
Bhikkhu *Analayo*
Introducing Mindfulness
Mindfulness of Breathing
Satipatthana: the Direct Path to Realization
Bhante Guneratana
Mindfulness in Plain English
Eight Mindful Steps to Happiness
The Four Foundations of Mindfulness in Plain English

Thich Nhat Hanh
Breathe! You Are Alive
Transformation and Healing
Paramitas
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Entering the Mind of Buddha
Norman Fischer
The World Could Be Otherwise
The Four Immeasurable Minds
Sharon Salzburg
Loving Kindness: The Revolutionary Art of Happiness
B. Alan Wallace
The Four Immeasurables: Practices to Open the Heart
Buddhist-Oriented Recovery
Recovery Dharma
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Noah Levine
Refuge Recovery
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Kevin Griffen
One Breath at a Time: Buddhism and the Twelve Steps
Others
Desmond Tutu and the Dalai Lama

The Book of Joy
The Dali Lama and Howard Cutler
The Art of Happiness
Norman Fischer
Training in Compassion

Appendix

The Four Noble Truths

There is suffering in life.
Our suffering has a cause.
Our suffering can end.
There is a path to the end of suffering.

The Eight Fold Path

Wise View
understanding the fact of suffering
understanding the origin of suffering
understanding its cessation
understanding the way leading to its cessation
Wise Intention
intention of renunciation
intention of good will
intention of harmlessness
Wise Speech
abstaining from false speech
abstaining from slanderous speech
abstaining from harsh speech
abstaining from idle chatter

Wise Action
abstaining from taking life
abstaining from stealing
abstaining from sexual misconduct
Wise Livelihood
giving up wrong livelihood
earning one's living without causing suffering
Wise Effort
effort to restrain defilements from arising
effort to abandon defilements the have arisen
effort to cause wholesome state to arise
effort to maintain arisen wholesome states
Wise Mindfulness
mindful contemplation of the body
mindful contemplation of feelings
mindful contemplation of the mind
mindful contemplation of phenomena
Wise Concentration
sila (virtue)
samadhi (concentration)
prajna (wisdom)

Confessions of a Jittery Mind

Dharma talk at the North Carolina Zen Center
Sheldon Clark

I don't usually title my talks, but in this case it seemed appropriate. I call this "Confessions of a Jittery Mind."

There are a few memes about meditation I've seen that I really like. One is a Buddhist monk deep in meditation with a large speech bubble above his head. Where each line of text should go, the speech bubble is empty until you get to the very bottom where two words appear: ice cream. Another meme is a split frame image of someone such as you or me, also deep in meditation. On the left, which is titled "What Other People See," there is an image of the meditator with a large, empty speech bubble. The righthand image of the same meditator, titled 'What is in My Mind," is the same person seemingly deep in meditation. There is a large speech bubble above her, filled with an image of the person looking desperately at her watch.

This is something we all face sometimes—a difficulty holding steady in meditation, with keeping our center, when we engage with thoughts rather than simply observing their presence and allowing them to pass. This is from a journal entry I wrote after a meditation retreat last year:

> *"I was amazed and disheartened by the images and wandering thoughts I experienced in during this retreat. It really was just sensory indulgence—a a snippet of a favorite movie, a song's refrain, memories from the family reunion last summer. And I was thinking about things that weren't pleasant, replaying my divorce 30 years ago, that heartbreak, and then trying to push it away. And I felt so tired. I kept allowing my eyes to close and my mind to drift, and I was having difficulty with my koan—wondering and doubting if koans really are the right path for me.*
>
> *I swear, I was beset by the hindrances. I kept getting swept away in them, unmindful that they were even happening. I know that when I am unmindful, hindrances can envelop my mind and obstruct my ability to see clearly, to understand what is real and what's not real… what's skillful and not skillful.*
>
> *And I tried so hard to get a handle on it, to work skillfully with the hindrances that were impeding me, but it was so hard."*

I went on in the journal to use the phrase "my jittery mind." And friends, often enough that's exactly what I have.

There's a wonderful simile in one of the sutras that talks about how the hindrances can obscure our perceptions, making it difficult for our minds to function clearly. Consider a pool of clear water that you might look down into to see what is at the bottom…

- When sense desire is present in the mind, it's as if the pool is suffused with a colored dye, brilliant and attractive, but which changes the way we perceive what is really in the water.
- When anger and aversion are present, it's as though the water is boiling hot, and the mind is seething in turbulence.
- When drowsiness and lethargy are present, the pool is overgrown with algae and there is a strong stagnation in the mind.
- When we experience restlessness and worry, it's like water that's stirred up by wind, and the mind is tossed about from one thing to another on the waves.
- When we are doubtful, the water is muddy, turbid, and our mind's clarity is obscured.

Now, distraction in meditation is part of the game, and we can't really blame ourselves for it, because thinking is what the brain is meant to do. Every meditation tradition, Buddhist or otherwise, offers thoughts on what to do in the face of distraction. But to make things even more mysterious, we might ask from the Zen perspective, is there even such a thing as distraction?

Ṭhānissaro Bhikkhu, a Buddhist Thervadan monk and author, once wrote that when we follow certain trains of thought, we develop mental habits which go along with them. When we react negatively to what we perceive as distractions, Ṭhānissaro asks, are we developing the thing our meditation is meant to develop? Are we developing a sense of calm, or are we developing turmoil? Are we developing mental stability, or are we developing a restless mind?

What are we do do? Try to block out distractions? For me, that becomes its own difficulty, a losing battle which leaves me frustrated, more distracted than ever. It's not a workable solution.

So, how do we get to the heart of this? Maybe we can start by looking at the logistical aspects of meditation.

What's our state of mind coming into the meditation hall? I make it a point not to listen to the news, or even to music on the way here, but to begin to settle my mind before I even arrive.

And once we're here in the zendo, how do we begin our meditation? There's getting into our physical posture, of course, and we can use settling breaths to deepen ourselves physically and energetically. And there's a mental posture, too—one of intention. As I sit and begin to settle, I set an intention to take this time to practice, to honor and build my presence *here*, in the hall and with sangha, as a support for my presence out in the world. But these are easy, surface level things. Let's look more deeply.

Meditation is a practice, learning to sit comfortably in the "dharma gate of bliss and repose," as Eihei Dogen said. We have to learn this, to be comfortable and aware in our bodies, comfortable and aware in our minds. We have to find these things, and sometimes it feels like I can't find either. Maybe that's true for you, too.

But I know that we have to be patient with ourselves. Patient with our own process, patient with the time it takes for our practice to grow. And for me, to be accepting of those times when, in spite of my intention and effort, I come in here with my body, but remain out there in my mind.

It's helped me to bring a compassionate forebearance to this—a fundamental and conscious change in my response to it. Experiencing aversion to my own wandering mind is a trap I've fallen into many times, and it's helped me to remember Ṭhānissaro's question: Am I developing a sense of calm in those times, or am I developing turmoil? Impatience, and a desire for "better" meditation, is a hindrance I've often indulged, and it can be tumultuous. So I've developed a sense of forbearance for my wandering mind, patience with my process, with my practice. This feels a little deeper, but let's keep looking.

For me, understanding my home in the three treasures, taking this into my heart, is so grounding. I find that the act of taking refuge—the actual recitation and the prostrations—reminds me of qualities within myself that are attuned to the Buddha's path and to recognize, in that moment, the life of the Buddha, dharma, and sangha within myself. When I really feel Buddha, dharma and sangha as lived realities, it helps me to deal skillfully with circumstances in my lives.

It's not that taking refuge makes my problems go away. But by relying on the example of the Buddha, the wisdom of the dharma, and the support of sangha, keeping these things close to my heart, I find that I'm able to transform my response to a variety of life's hardships. Jeffrey Shugen Arnold, the abbot of the Mountains and Rivers Order in New York state, wrote that, "Taking refuge involves taking a leap forward with a deep sense of trust in our own basic nature. Buddha, dharma, and sangha are the real activity of compassion that has been passed down through many generations. They point to how real people seek real truth in a particular time and place." This feels closer to home, but let's go deeper.

Our True Nature is Eternal, Joyous, Selfless and Pure. We just chanted this in the Kannon Sutra — *jo raku ga jo.* In a letter recommending the Kanzeon chant to a friend, Hakuin wrote, "Because it is so brief, I sincerely hope that you will recite this two or three hundred times each day." Our True Nature is Eternal, Joyous, Selfless and Pure — *jo raku ga jo*.

Suzuki Roshi, from the San Francisco Zen Center, used to say that our individual, small mind is not separate from what he called big Mind, the integrated wholeness of life—that our small, individual mind is actually an expression of big Mind.

That's hard to fathom sometimes, but I take it on faith. Koun Yamada Roshi wrote, "Great faith means believing, without any doubt, that you are intrinsically awake, that all beings are intrinsically awake. Great faith also means believing that every person is in the process of eventually achieving supreme enlightenment." Our True Nature is Eternal, Joyous, Selfless and Pure. This feels true, and hopeful.

Yes, some things we can just accept with faith. But let's get down to practice, here in the moment. I've always loved the opening passage of the Anapanasati sutra, one of only a few where the Buddha addressed the subject of meditation directly.

> *I heard these words of the Buddha one time when he was staying in Savatthi. That night the moon was full. The Buddha, the Awakened One, was sitting in the open air, and his disciples were gathered around him. After looking over the assembly, he began to speak:*
>
> *Friends, our community is pure and good. Such a community is rare, and any pilgrim who seeks it, no matter how far she must travel, will find it worthy. Friends, the full awareness of breathing, if developed and practiced continuously, will be rewarding and bring great advantage. And what is the way to develop and practice continuously the method of Full Awareness of Breathing?*
>
> *It is like this: the practitioner goes into the forest, or to the foot of a tree, or to any quiet place, sits stably, holding his or her body straight, and practices like this: 'Breathing in, I know I am breathing in. Breathing out,*

I know I am breathing out.'

It's just so simple—that's what I keep telling myself. But as anyone who's tried it can tell you, it can also be just that hard.

So, here's a perspective that's been the most helpful for me. In a dharma talk, Paul Haller, a priest at the San Francisco Zen Center, spoke of the difference between "directed attention"and "receptive attention." Directed attention is what it sounds like, when we *bring* our attention to an input from our senses, including our thoughts, which the Buddha considered as input from a sixth sensory organ, the mind itself.

The difficulty with directed attention, though, is that we tend to bring things along with it— impressions from past events, our preconceived ideas, our values, our judgments. All of these accompany our directed attention, and our awareness of sensory experience is changed by them, colored by them, disrupted by them.

With receptive attention we leave all of that behind. When we meet sensory input, including thought, with receptive attention, our awareness doesn't extend outward. Rather, we invite sensations to reach inward to meet us, honest in their nature, unadorned, unencumbered.

For me, meditation is always more clear when I bring receptive attention to the sensation of my experience, rather than directed attention and its attempts to examine experience. With receptive attention we engage sensations, such as hindering emotions and thoughts, in a way that allows them to simply show their nature: doubt, worry. In this way, the sensation of these things becomes more vital than our effort to interpret them, or our propensity to just be swept along by them. "I'm experiencing doubt. I'm experiencing sense desire." When we engage in this way, we find something being expressed, and we can stand intuitively with the real nature of what is happening.

For me, the root of being able to do this is a practice of non-attachment, being able to just observe things such as doubt, or desire, or worry without clinging to an immersion in their stories. Rather they can be something more simple… just the *sensation* of doubt, the sensation of desire or worry, without the cloying, distracting stories I might otherwise concoct around them.

So here's what I think I know… that distractions in meditation don't actually exist. How could they? As Zen practitioners, we value an understanding of non-duality, of the inherent oneness of things. "Things as it is," you may have heard me quote Suzuki Roshi before. "Things as it is."

A cough in the meditation hall, an itch on the face, or a recurring thought, are these distractions which separate us from our concentration? Or are they *part* of our field of awareness, just needing to be seen as such? To be understood as such? To be welcomed in our awareness with the same attention, the same value and acceptance as we welcome one, clear breath?

It's a subtle shift. Simple, like I said, but for me, per-haps, the practice of a lifetime.

The Anapanasati Sutra

(as translated by Bhikkhu Analayo)[18]

I

I heard these words of the Buddha one time when he was staying in Savatthi in the Eastern Park, with many well-known and accomplished disciples. The senior bhikkhus in the community were diligently instructing bhikkhus who were new to the practice — some instructing ten bhikkhus, some twenty, some thirty, and some forty; and in this way the bhikkhus who were new to the practice gradually made great progress.

That night the moon was full, and the Pavarana Ceremony was held to mark the end of the rainy-season retreat. Lord Buddha, the Awakened One, was sitting in the open air, and his disciples were gathered around him. After looking over the assembly, he began to speak:

"O bhikkhus, I am pleased to observe the fruit you have attained in your practice. Yet I know you can make even more progress. What you have not yet attained, you can attain. What you have not yet realized, you can realize perfectly. [To engage your efforts,] I will remain here until the next full-moon day."

When they heard that the Lord Buddha was going to remain in Savatthi for another month, bhikkhus throughout the country began traveling there to study with him. The senior bhikkhus continued teaching the bhikkhus new to the practice even more ardently. Some were instructing ten bhikkhus, some twenty, some thirty, and some forty. With this help, the newer bhikkhus were able, little by little, to continue their progress in understanding.

When the next full-moon day arrived, the Buddha, seated under the open sky, looked over the assembly of bhikkhus and began to speak: "O bhikkhus, our community is pure and good. At its heart, it is without useless and boastful talk, and therefore it deserves to receive offerings and be considered a field of merit. Such a community is rare, and any pilgrim who seeks it, no matter how far he must travel, will find it worthy.

"O bhikkhus, there are bhikkhus in this assembly who have realized the fruit of Arhatship, destroyed every root of affliction, laid aside every burden, and attained right understanding and emancipation. There are also bhikkhus who have cut off the first five internal knots and realized the fruit of never returning to the cycle of birth and death.

"There are those who have thrown off the first three internal knots and realized the fruit of returning once more. They have cut off the roots of greed, hatred, and ignorance, and will only need to return to the cycle of birth and death one more time. There are those who have thrown off the three internal knots and attained the fruit of stream-enterer, coursing steadily to the Awakened State. There are those who practice the Four Establishments of Mindfulness. There are those who practice the Four Right Efforts, and those who practice the Four Bases of Success. There are those who practice the Five Faculties, those who practice the Five Powers, those who practice the Seven Factors of Awakening, and those who practice the Noble Eightfold Path. There are those who practice loving kindness, those who practice compassion, those who practice joy, and those who practice equanimity. There are those who practice the Nine Contemplations, and those who practice the Observation of Impermanence. There are also bhikkhus who are already practicing Full Awareness of Breathing."

II

"O bhikkhus, the full awareness of breathing, if developed and practiced continuously, will be rewarding and bring great advantages. It will lead to success in practicing the Four Establishments of Mindfulness. If the method of the Four Establishments of Mindfulness is developed and practiced continuously, it will lead to success in the practice of the Seven Factors of Awaking. The Seven Factors of Awakening, if developed and practiced continuously, will give rise to understanding and liberation of the mind.

"What is the way to develop and practice continuously the method of Full Awareness of Breathing so that the practice will be rewarding and offer great benefit?

"It is like this, bhikkhus: the practitioner goes into the forest or to the foot of a tree, or to any deserted place, sits stably in the lotus position, holding his or her body quite straight, and practices like this: 'Breathing in, I know I am breathing in. Breathing out, I know I am breathing out.'

1. 'Breathing in a long breath, I know I am breathing in a long breath. Breathing out a long breath, I know I am breathing out a long breath. He or she practices like this.
2. 'Breathing in a short breath, I know I am breathing in a short breath. Breathing out a short breath, I know I am breathing out a short breath. He or she practices like this.
3. 'Breathing in, I am aware of my whole body. Breathing out, I am aware of my whole body.' He or she practices like this.
4. 'Breathing in, I calm my whole body. Breathing out, I calm my whole body.' He or she practices like this.
5. 'Breathing in, I feel joyful. Breathing out, I feel joyful.' He or she practices like this.
6. 'Breathing in, I feel happy. Breathing out, I feel happy.' He or she practices like this.
7. 'Breathing in, I am aware of my mental formations. Breathing out, I am aware of my mental formations.' He or she practices like this.
8. 'Breathing in, I calm my mental formations. Breathing out, I calm my mental formations.' He or she practices like this.
9. 'Breathing in, I am aware of my mind. Breathing out, I am aware of my mind.' He or she practices like this.
10. 'Breathing in, I make my mind happy. Breathing out, I make my mind happy.' He or she practices like this.
11. 'Breathing in, I concentrate my mind. Breathing out, I concentrate my mind.' He or she practices like this.
12. 'Breathing in, I liberate my mind. Breathing out, I liberate my mind.' He or she practices like this.
13. 'Breathing in, I observe the impermanent nature of all dharmas. Breathing out, I observe the impermanent nature of all dharmas.' He or she practices like this.
14. 'Breathing in, I observe the disappearance of desire. Breathing out, I observe the disappearance of desire.' He or she practices like this.
15. 'Breathing in, I observe the no-birth, no-death nature of all phenomena. Breathing out, I observe the no-birth, no-death nature of all phenomena.' He or she practices like this.
16. 'Breathing in, I observe letting go. Breathing out, I observe letting go.' He or she practices like this.

"The Full Awareness of Breathing, if developed and practiced continuously according to these instructions, will be rewarding and of great benefit."

III

“In what way does one develop and continuously practice the Full Awareness of Breathing, in order to succeed in the practice of the Four Establishments of Mindfulness?

“When the practitioner breathes in or out a long or a short breath, aware of his breath or his whole body, or aware that he is making his whole body calm and at peace, he abides peacefully in the observation of the body in the body, persevering, fully awake, clearly understanding his state, gone beyond all attachment and aversion to this life. These exercises of breathing with Full Awareness belong to the First Establishment of Mindfulness, the body.

“When the practitioner breathes in or out aware of joy or happiness, of the mental formations, or to make the mental formations peaceful, he abides peacefully in the observation of the feelings in the feelings, persevering, fully awake, clearly understanding his state, gone beyond all attachment and aversion to this life. These exercises of breathing with Full Awareness belong to the Second Establishment of Mindfulness, the feelings.

“When the practitioner breathes in or out with the awareness of the mind, or to make the mind happy, to collect the mind in concentration, or to free and liberate the mind, he abides peacefully in the observation of the mind in the mind, persevering, fully awake, clearly understanding his state, gone beyond all attachment and aversion to this life. These exercises of breathing with Full Awareness belong to the Third Establishment of Mindfulness, the mind. Without Full Awareness of Breathing, there can be no development of meditative stability and understanding.

“When the practitioner breathes in or breathes out and contemplates the essential impermanence or the essential disappearance of desire or the no-birth, no-death nature of all phenomena or letting go, he abides peacefully in the observations of the objects of mind in the objects of mind, persevering, fully awake, clearly understanding his state, gone beyond all attachment and aversion to this life. These exercises of breathing with Full Awareness belong to the Fourth Establishment of Mindfulness, the objects of mind.

“The practice of Full Awareness of Breathing, if developed and practiced continuously, will lead to perfect accomplishment of the Four Establishments of Mindfulness.”

IV

“Moreover, if they are developed and continuously practiced, the Four Establishments of Mindfulness will lead to perfect abiding in the Seven Factors of Awakening. How is this so?

“When the practitioner can maintain, without distraction, the practice of observing the body in the body, the feelings in the feelings, the mind in the mind, and the objects of mind in the objects of mind, persevering, fully awake, clearly understanding her state, gone beyond all attachment and aversion to this life, with unwavering, steadfast, imperturbable meditative stability, she will attain the First Factor of Awakening, namely mindfulness. When this factor is developed, it will come to perfection.

“When the practitioner can abide in meditative stability without being distracted and can investigate every dharma, every object of mind that arises, then the Second Factor of Awakening will be born and developed in her, the factor of investigating dharmas. When this factor is developed, it will come to perfection.

“When the practitioner can observe and investigate every dharma in a sustained, persevering, and steadfast way, without being distracted, the Third Factor of Awakening will be born and developed in her, the factor of energy. When this factor is developed, it will come to perfection.

“When the practitioner has reached a stable, imperturbable abiding in the stream of practice, the Fourth Factor of Awakening will be born and developed in her, the factor of joy. When this factor is developed, it will come to perfection.

“When the practitioner can abide undistractedly in the state of joy, she will feel her body and mind light and at peace. At this point the Fifth Factor of Awakening will be born and developed, the factor of ease. When this factor is developed, it will come to perfection.

“When both body and mind are at ease, the practitioner can easily enter into concentration. At this point the Sixth Factor of Awakening will be born and developed in her, the factor of concentration. When this factor is developed, it will come to perfection.

“When the practitioner is abiding in concentration with deep calm, she will cease discriminating and comparing. At this point the Seventh Factor of Awakening is released, born, and developed in her, the factor of letting go. When this factor is developed, it will come to perfection.

“This is how the Four Establishments of Mindfulness, if developed and practiced continuously, will lead to perfect abiding in the Seven Factors of Awakening.”

V

“How will the Seven Factors of Awakening, if developed and practiced continuously, lead to the perfect accomplishment of true understanding and complete liberation?

“If the practitioner follows the path of the Seven Factors of Awakening, living in quiet seclusion, observing and contemplating the disappearance of desire, he will develop the capacity of letting go. This will be a result of following the path of the Seven Factors of Awakening and will lead to the perfect accomplishment of true understanding and complete liberation.”

VI

This is what the Lord, the Awakened One, said; and everyone in the assembly felt gratitude and delight at having heard his teachings.